

Local Food: Perceptions, Motivations, Community

By

Alice Reznickova

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The dissertation is approved by the following members of the Final Oral Committee:

Alfonso Morales, Professor, Urban and Regional Planning

Patricia Loew, Professor, Life Sciences Communication

Eve Emshwiller, Associate Professor, Botany

Samer Alatout, Associate Professor, Community and Environmental Sociology

Greg Lawless, Program Manager, University of Wisconsin - Extension

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Introduction

Questioning local food

As many others, I too first learned about local food from *Omnivore's Dilemma* (Pollan, 2006) and *Food Inc.* (Pearlstein and Kenner, 2006). At the edge of my seat in a small movie theater I was astonished by the atrocities committed by the industrial food system and excited about the new direction of the food systems towards sustainability. This was my entry point to involvement with the food systems and later the reason why I became a graduate student in Environment & Resources at the University of Wisconsin – Madison determined to work towards introducing more people to local food, thus increasing sales of these “heroic” producers.

The five years of my studies have been wild with learning challenges. The self-design of my program allowed me to take a variety of classes with professors whose minds I admired. I first began to question my assumptions about what local food systems are in an ethnobotany course: what makes “local” food local given the rich history of human interactions with food? Next, I was challenged with my assumption about the sustainability of the local food systems: in what ways, if any, and to what extent are they more sustainable than other alternatives? My last questions -- the ones that became the focal point of my research and teaching -- were about human behavior and the big picture: how does local food fit into our world? The questions I asked evolved over time as I walked through the large body of literature, research projects about local food, but also personal experiences in my community.

This process was long, challenging, and produced more questions than I started with almost five years ago. The development of my thoughts follows the path of the four food discourses set by Mares and Alkon (2011). This framework gives context to both my career and my projects and for this reason I have adopted it as a centerpiece of this introduction.

The four food discourses

In 2011, Teresa Marie Mares and Alison Hope Alkon wrote an overview that both highlighted and critiqued the four major food systems discourses: local food, community food security, food justice, and food sovereignty. The authors considered the local food discourse to be the most prominent of the four and my research has led me to agree. This framework, based on the assumed importance of local food for environmental, social and economic sustainability, highlights the importance of individual consumption choices within the market.

Both Pollan's (2006) and Food Inc.'s (2006) rhetoric of ethical and political consumption expressed by the sentiment of "voting with our dollars" is an essential part of this discourse. In literature, this discourse emerges in studies that strive to characterize the local food shopper for the purpose of designing interventions to promote consumption of food sold at farmers' markets or through Community Supported Agriculture (CSA) (e.g. Megicks et al., 2012; Zepeda & Nie, 2011). These studies imply that if we understand the individual, we can "help" some interested parties modify consumer behavior.

A major critique of this discourse is its location within the broader neoliberalist framework that shifts the responsibility of the government to the individual and to the marketplace. It assumes that anyone can access local food, if, as Julie Guthman (2008) writes, "they only knew" about it. However, this discourse disregards individual realities, making it particularly harmful to low-income communities and communities of color. Of course, a significant problem associated with the critique is its inability to explain how people do come to a critique of the food system, do manage to create access opportunities, and do in fact change society, even if incrementally, by their emergent ideas and activities.

Thus, the notion of individual responsibility for “embettering” oneself is inescapable, and woven into our social fabric across subjects ranging from healthcare to education. In her *Eating Right in America: The cultural politics of food and health*, Charlotte Biltekoff (2013) argues that this desire to prescribe what is “right” to eat to some “others” is rooted in reassuring ourselves about our position in society. This discourse of individual responsibility and need to change disregards individual differences in political, economic, historical, and cultural contexts. In this way, this discourse signals to others within different contexts that if they do not eat like us, they are not a part of our community.

The second critique concerns local food markets that cultivate an image of being “alternative.” By claiming a tight connection between producers and consumers, these local food markets position themselves against the industrial, profiteering giants (Alkon, 2008; Kato, 2014; Thompson & Coskuner-Bali, 2007). However, as Clare Hinrichs (2000) points out, it is important to recognize that they are in fact using similar market strategies to survive despite cloaking themselves in ethical rhetoric. Whether they could aspire to be different is an important question: based on Laura DeLind’s (1999) experience --founding and running an “idealist’s” CSA with explicit community-oriented goals -- divorce from market mechanisms is unlikely. This challenges the romantic notion that these markets are places where “concerned” consumers purchase food from “ethical” producers (Weatherell et al., 2003). Could they simultaneously be places where consumers with means purchase food? And if that is the case, are they simply another mechanism for propagating inequality?

Community food security challenges the local food discourse by highlighting the differences in food access across communities and attempting to provide and evaluate solutions.

Community food security thus recognizes some aspects of context rather than claiming that all can access local food equally.

Some of these strategies to promote food access include non-monetary transactions such as food procurement in food pantries and free meal distribution sites, which have become increasingly connected to the local food movement through obtaining produce from local farmers (Vitiello et al., 2015). However, others, including farmers' markets in low income neighborhoods (Reznickova & Zepeda, 2016), CSA with subsidies (Hinrichs & Kramer, 2002), or mobile markets (Zepeda et al., 2014) still rely on some ability to pay for good food.

This discourse is not dissimilar from the local food discourse: besides solutions resting on the same neoliberalist tenet of market solutions, individuals have a "responsibility" to choose to accept this "help" (Mares & Alkon, 2011). While some studies, for instance our study of customers and non-customers of mobile markets (Zepeda et al., 2014), focus on improving the service of providing fresh food, the underlying assumption is that these interventions should be desired by communities that are perceived as not having access to fresh and healthy food.

Of course, someone has to invest time, energy, and money into these solutions. More often than not, these projects are conducted by volunteering White "missionaries," such as college students on a summer break (Guthman, 2008b), whose values and ideals are based on their own worldviews and who believe that if they educate and expose others to local food, the community will embrace it (Lyson, 2014). By demonstrating a lack of understanding of individual communities and inherent inequality, these projects often end up frustrated (Guthman, 2008b).

The food justice discourse addresses this by explicitly discussing how racism and classism are the underlying causes of these inequalities. Mares and Alkon (2011) present a

“celebratory volume” *Cultivating food justice: Race, class, and sustainability* (Alkon & Agyeman, 2011) that provides case studies of the struggles of and solutions proposed by a number of communities in food justice.

However, it is important to note that food justice as a lens or interpretive tool is limited due to the need for participation of those who are most affected by inequalities, low-income communities of color. Morales (2014) points out the historical policy injustices producing contemporary problems for food access and food justice. Besides historical understanding, food justice requires leadership in food movement from communities that often lack the necessary capital, be it economic, natural, built, or political. One such example are community gardens in Milwaukee, where White leadership assumed their positions due to their greater time availability, access to resources, and knowledge of bureaucratic procedures (Ghose & Pettigrove, 2014). The food justice movement can also be challenged by differences in values, experiences and rhetoric of White activists and activists of color; this may lead to lack of understanding and divided goals (Lyson, 2014). In addition, this discourse assumes that everyone would like to be responsible for their own food procurement. For instance, an organization in Seattle faced difficulties of mobilizing African-American neighborhoods due to their ignorance of the complex history of slavery and how it affected the current generation’s desire to participate in farming (Ramirez, 2014).

The last discourse, food sovereignty, is the only one that did not originate in the United States, and it is the only one that connects the local to the global. Based on La Via Campesina, which highlights the struggles of peasant farmers in Third World Countries, food sovereignty represents an attempt to address issues of resource distribution and the political climate surrounding food production and consumption (Mares & Alkon, 2011). The authors find some

emerging evidence of this discourse in the United States context; for instance, urban gardeners in New York City use this discourse to describe the solutions to inequality. However, some academics argue that due to its origins, this discourse will never be applicable to the United States. Mares and Alkon (2011) conclude the article with discussion of the potential of this discourse and the need for more research.

This work in the context of the four discourses

The first three of the four discourses greatly influenced the development of this dissertation and the majority of them is rooted in the local food rhetoric. The first project I was a part of attempted to elucidate the reasons for low CSA retention rates (Oberholtzer, 2004). Based on our results, we provided some advice for CSA farmers to recruit and retain members (Zepeda et al., 2013).

During my second semester of graduate school, my work took a different direction due to three major influences. I became more engaged with the works of Alison Hope Alkon, Patricia Allen, Laura DeLind, Julie Guthman, Clare Hinrichs and others; their work focused on identifying and challenging the neoliberalist assumptions of the food systems discourses. Through my classes in social psychology and environmental sociology, I began to locate human behavior not only in the human mind, but also within the political, cultural, social, and economic context. Last, a contract from the United States Department of Agriculture I joined as a research assistant brought me to the world of mobile markets, and thus connected me with the community food security and food justice discourses. Under these three influences, I began to question the local food discourse and moved towards its successors: community food security and food justice.

My original dissertation plan thus consisted of examining the local food discourse itself and its possible effect, exclusion of certain people or communities. I hypothesized that this exclusion could be based on differing definitions of local food and different reasons to use local food, which would divide people into different communities, some more privileged than others. For this reason, I planned to interview participants from what I viewed as two extremes of local food involvement: local food producers and sellers and low-income, minority residents who are not often seen in local food markets (Brown, 2003; Payne, 2002).

In the way I interpreted “local food” in this proposal, I assumed that local food was equally relevant to all future participants of my study. In my proposal, all participants were framed as “users of local food,” but differed in their definition and reasons for use, which divided them into different communities. I predicted that these differences would explain why some are excluded from the “official” local food community.

Already the first interview revealed that my assumption was naïve and rooted in my privilege. Over and over I was finding that how I viewed “local food” was not relevant to the low-income participants of color who did not introduce local food into the conversation by themselves. In many cases, they did not know how to define local food or were not even interested in discussing it. As a result, it was impossible to write the studies I foresaw myself writing: since the participants did not define local food, there was no use in analyzing their reasons for procuring it or their membership in some relational community I dreamed up.

Regardless, the data still provided some insight into the exclusive nature of local food discourses. Thus, emboldened by my learning I conceived a new first article comprehending differences between the producers and local residents, and answering the question of whether the producers’ and non-customers’ views reflect personal responsibility of whether these groups

assign lack of purchases to the structural inequalities of the society. The differences between the two positions result in different policy suggestions to increase local food consumption. The second question emerged from the similarities in the rhetoric of the producers themselves: in describing their position in the local food world, they inherently uncovered some relationship to others who produced local food. In the second article, we therefore address this possibility of a community using the consumption community framework (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001) based on three community determinants: collective consciousness, rituals and traditions, and moral obligation. The second article describes whether and how these determinants are satisfied in this community and discusses their implications for group culture and inclusion. The last article is based on another data set of interviews with leaders of Slow Food at the University of Wisconsin - Madison, an organization that serves affordable local food at the university but also addresses some issues of social justice in South Madison. This article examines the organization's success, specifically it explains the self-propagation of this organization through the satisfaction of basic psychological needs (Deci & Ryan, 2000) of the members of this organization. This study thus has implications for organizational leadership and management and could be of interest to other local food promoting organizations.

The writing process

The data analysis and writing of the first two studies lasted approximately a year and a half. The first article will be re-submitted to Agriculture and Human Values after revisions, the second article is in review in International Journal of Consumer Studies. The last article, already published in Journal of Community and Applied Social Psychology (Reznickova and Zepeda,

2016), was written earlier and the process took approximately one year including submissions to different journals and revisions until publication.

The process of re-conceptualizing my work based on the data was extensive: the interviews were detailed narratives and the coding process including numerous analytical memos lasted approximately a year. This was mostly a result of managing a number of other projects and teaching; however, it also reflected changing worldviews: every time I approached the data, my understanding of local food was slightly altered and so was the view of the frameworks I wanted to use.

This project is a result of my work and frequent conversations and draft exchanges with the co-author of all three papers, Dr. Lydia Zepeda. I would attribute the result of these projects to learning, thinking, reading, and sometimes dreaming, activities, which are impossible to quantify. For this reason, it is impossible to completely represent the amount of work spent on this project. I believe that Table 1, which includes conceptualization, data collection, analysis, and writing is an accurate representation of the division of labor for each of the three papers.

The drafting process for each paper followed a number of conversations on the topic addressed in the paper, a general outline, a more detailed outline, an incomplete draft, and a number of more complete drafts. The number of drafts varied between the studies. The first author provided the drafts, the second author provided conceptual comments and edits to improve readability. In the last stages, a new introduction and conclusion to this dissertation were added and the rest of the dissertation was edited based on the suggestions of the members of my committee during the final examination. The final version was edited by my advisor, Alfonso Morales. The following work is therefore scientific in the most robust sense of the word,

the result of systematically deployed methods in a social context with many influences and much advice and much feedback.

Table 1. Contributions of both authors into the three articles of this dissertation (first author is the author of this dissertation)

Task	Article 1		Article 2		Article 3	
	First Author	Second author	First author	Second author	First author	Second author
Conceptualization	80	20	90	10	90	10
Data collection	95	5	95	5	5	95
Data analysis	90	10	90	10	90	10
Writing	90	10	80	20	80	20

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Article 1: Do you “care” enough to buy our products? Producers’, sellers’, and local low-income/minority residents’ perceptions about local food behaviors

Abstract

Research about local food has found that those who do not buy local food tend to be low-income and/or minorities. We explore what leaders in the local food community think about who these non-consumers are and why they do not buy local food. We contrast these perceptions with the perceptions of low-income and/or minorities about their own behaviors. We find that the leaders think local food is for everyone and believe that the people who do not buy it from them do not care about themselves, their health, and their community. Interviews with low-income and/or minority consumers reveal that they like fresh, healthy food and value commensality. They also produce and prepare this food in their homes. They do not buy the leaders’ local food because it is not culturally appropriate or affordable. This contrast highlights two different approaches to policy: for producers, education would instill attitudes they view as appropriate, which would result in purchases. On the other hand, consumers would appreciate affordable food they are familiar with. The leaders do not recognize that their rhetoric privileges themselves, while marginalizing low-income and/or minority people, their food preferences, and the way they procure local food.

Introduction

The number of local food direct-to-consumer venues increases every year (USDA ERS, 2014) with local food sales recently reaching \$6.1 billion (Low et al., 2015). Benefits of localized food systems include access to fresh produce for customers and increased revenues for

small farmers (Martinez et al., 2010). Other potential benefits, desired by local food activists, also include environmental sustainability and social justice (Allen, 2010; Feenstra, 1997).

However, some question to what extent social justice can be achieved given the market nature of the local food movement (Guthman, 2008c) and its exclusionary discourse (Alkon & McCullen, 2010; Guthman, 2008b; Slocum, 2007).

Local food rhetoric can be powerful when shared by leaders and “stars” of the local food movement. On the community level, the most visible leaders of the local food movement are producers and sellers. They are visible because they participate in local food policy councils and in non-profit organizations. Similar to the case of organic food (Meyers & Abrams, 2010), through media, local food rhetoric of producers and sellers can be shared far and wide. How they view and talk about people who buy and do not buy local food can have consequences for local food access policies, agenda and projects of non-profits, and according to Guthman (2008b), general exclusion from local food spaces.

How the leaders of the local food movement view those who do not buy local food and how they explain their motivation are therefore important questions. Literature has examined purchases of local food in direct-to-consumer venues to construct a portrait of a local food shopper based on positive attitudes (e.g. Dowd & Burke, 2013; Zepeda & Nie, 2012); those who do not purchase local food are identified as low-income and/or minorities (Brown, 2003; Payne, 2002). However, local food has now spread outside of farmers’ markets, farm stands, and Community Supported Agriculture (CSA) into value-added production, food service, and retail. While we know that the rhetoric of farmers’ market and CSA managers about their customers and non-customers can be exclusionary (Guthman, 2008b), we do not know how the local food

leaders from these new spaces describe their non-customers and whether their non-customers explain their own behaviors in the same way.

The purpose of this case study therefore is to document the perceptions of prominent local food producers and sellers about who does not buy local food and why. We chose to conduct this study in Madison, Wisconsin because of its rich local food culture. We interviewed 12 producers and sellers about the motivations of their non-customers and to assess the accuracy of these perceptions, we compared and contrasted their beliefs with the perceptions of ten low-income and/or minority local residents who are less likely to be seen in local food spaces (Brown, 2003; Payne, 2002; Slocum, 2007) about their own experiences. This study used a grounded theory approach in that our findings emerged from the narratives of the participants themselves rather than being imposed by a pre-existing set of variables.

This study has implications for local food advocates and policy makers due to identifying variables that these two groups perceive to be relevant in determining local food related behaviors. Both groups thus hint at specific strategies to promote procurement of local food. We further report and discuss the implications of these suggested strategies for both monetary and non-monetary local food procurement in low-income and/or minority communities.

Literature Review

In the United States, marketplaces have a rich history, (Morales 2000, 2009) and an important role in community health, as well as social, economic and political life (Morales 2011). Marketplaces in general, and farmers' markets in particular play an important role in increasing local food purchases, which have been attributed to consumers' desire for fresh, high quality, healthy produce (Feldman and Hamm, 2015; Puciarelli et al., 2014). Local food

purchases also have symbolic meaning. Farmers' markets and CSA purchases can represent preference for social interactions (Feagan et al., 2004) and signal consumers' values. Values that predict local food purchases include concern about local agriculture and farmers (Cranfield et al., 2012), sustainable food (Megicks et al., 2012), environmental concern (Zepeda and Nie, 2012), and ethics in general (Dowd and Burke, 2013). Those direct-to-consumer venues are thus considered to be spaces where "concerned" consumers act on their values (Weatherell et al., 2003) and writers such as Michael Pollan (2006) can write about the ethical values associated with local food consumption.

On the other hand, Slocum (2007) informally observed that local food spaces, be it farmers' markets or local food cooperatives, are mostly filled with White bodies and not bodies of color. This is confirmed in other literature; both farmers' market customers and CSA members are disproportionately White (Payne, 2002; Schnell, 2013; Zepeda & Carroll, 2016). Access could play a role in this exclusion: despite the growth in numbers (USDA ERS, 2015), farmers' markets are more likely to be in White affluent neighborhoods (Schupp, 2015; Roubal and Morales 2016). However, even in more diverse neighborhoods, farmers' markets patrons were more affluent outsiders motivated to support African-American farmers (Alkon & Mares, 2012). Social justice oriented markets in marginalized neighborhoods also reported issues with attracting clientele from their own neighborhood (Kato & McKinney, 2015).

On average, local food shoppers have higher income (Brown, 2003; Eastwood et al., 1999). Often, even venues that attempted to directly address affordability reported difficulties with attracting low-income customers. Despite almost 4,100 markets having the capability to accept EBT, the redemption rate of \$22.5 million from farmers' market accounts for only 0.03% of total EBT redemption (USDA FNS, 2013). A CSA that used a subsidy to attract more low-

income members still reported membership that was more affluent than regional averages (Hinrichs & Kremer, 2003). However, some markets have been more successful; for instance, a farmers' market that promoted ethnic produce in a low-income, diverse neighborhood of Worcester, Massachusetts, recorded that almost 50% of its transactions were EBT (Reznickova & Zepeda, 2016).

While academics have been studying farmers' markets and CSA customers for the past 30 years, Guthman's (2008b) study of the perceptions of farmers' market and CSA managers in California is unique because it suggested that local food leaders viewed their venues as places of "universal values." They believed that those who participated in them had values similar to them, while those who did not were perceived as "others." Guthman (2008b) connected the expression of universal values with colorblindness; her participants did not see lack of diversity as a problem that needed to be addressed at their markets. Guthman (2008b) argues that this can make the market feel not welcoming.

However, just like the many studies of local food purchases described above, Guthman's (2008b) study did not ask those who did not participate about their values. Were the perceptions of these farmers' market and CSA managers accurate? Guthman (2008b) suggested searching for clues in Caroline Finney's (2006) study of national parks. In this study, White participants believed that values were a predictor of national parks' visits, which implies that those who did not visit had different values. In contrast, African-American participants indicated that exclusionary practices, not different values, could prevent people from visiting. Applying this to Guthman's (2008b) study, universalism and colorblindness prevented acknowledgment of people who did not make purchases in alternative food systems; already vulnerable communities may have felt excluded as a result. This implies that the rhetoric Guthman (2008b) describes at

farmers' markets and CSA might propagate exclusion of those who do not participate in them through purchases.

However, local food is not confined to those spaces alone. Local food now includes both local produce and value-added products; both are sold at other venues including low-end and high-end retailers such as Wal-Mart (Clifford, 2010) and Whole Foods (Whole Foods Market, n.d.), as well as used to some extent in fast casual restaurants such as Chipotle (Liebelson, 2013) and in fine dining establishments (National Restaurant Association, 2009). In 2007, total local food sales were estimated at \$5 billion, which was approximately four times more than direct-to-consumer sales alone (Packaged Foods, 2007). Those who run the new local food venues often participate in governance, non-profit organizations, and their voices are heard through media. Can Guthman's (2008b) conclusions be applied to these new local food leaders as well? Our first research question therefore is:

RQ 1: How do local food producers and sellers explain the motivations of local residents who do not purchase their products?

To address whether these perceptions are accurate and therefore whether the policies and programs based on these perceptions would be appropriate, we compare and contrast them with local residents' self-perception of their local food behaviors. Our second research question therefore is:

RQ2: Are the local food producers'/sellers' perceptions about their non-customers accurate when compared to the perceptions of local minority and/or low-income residents who are not likely to purchase their product about their own behaviors? Why or why not?

Methods

The purpose of this study was to explore the accuracy of producers'/sellers' perceptions of non-customers by comparing them to the perceptions of low-income and/or minority local residents have of their own experiences with local food. Madison, Wisconsin is an appropriate site because while it has a rich local food landscape, some parts of the city are USDA designated food deserts (USDA ERS, 2015). Furthermore, local food producers and sellers participate in the local food culture and governance including the city policy council (City of Madison, n.d.) and on the boards of two non-profit organizations (FairShare, n.d., REAP Food Group, n.d.) that are highly visible to the Madison community through a number of events.

Due to its exploratory nature, this study is anchored in grounded theory and qualitative methodology (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). Instead of employing pre-conceived frames and categories, we were interested in allowing the complexity of the data to emerge from the participants' discourse (McCracken, 1988). Semi-structured in-depth interviews were deemed an appropriate method because they allow for consistency of questions across participants but also offer the flexibility of following themes that are important to the participant or to the researcher (Legard et al., 2003). The narratives that emerge from qualitative interviews are rich, detailed and they represent the participants' own meaning in their voice (Holstein & Gubrium, 1995).

Prior to recruitment, the study design was approved by the Institutional Review Board. The producers and sellers were identified and recruited by a co-author, who ensured that the

participants self-identified or promoted themselves as producing and/or selling local food. In addition, they all operated or sold in White, affluent neighborhoods of Madison where many local food businesses operate (Table 2) (Madison Neighborhood Indicators, 2015).

All participants' demographic characteristics are summarized in Table 2 for producers and sellers and Table 3 for consumers. In both Table 2 and 3 and hereafter in this manuscript, the participants will be referred to using aliases. The purpose of this is to protect their identity and confidentiality. The aliases were selected at random from databases of the most popular names for the ethnicity/race each participant self-identified with.

Local food producers/sellers were selected to represent a variety of different businesses; we included farmers, producers of value-added products, restaurant owners, and retailers. These four groups were selected because they represented the groups of local food producers and sellers that are involved in local food policy council and/or being on a board of directors of a local food promoting non-profit organization in Madison, Wisconsin. Each of the four groups included three participants to make a total of 12 participants. This sample allowed us to see whether the producers and sellers had similar views because they identified as being involved with local food or whether they had different perceptions due to the differences of their venues or products they offered.

The selected producers/sellers were contacted via e-mail and asked to participate in this study. Almost all those contacted responded and agreed to schedule an interview. The exceptions to this were four farmers and two national chains that sell local food in Madison who did not respond to an invitation and a follow-up email.

The second group of participants, hereafter referred to as "consumers," were low-income and/or minority Madison residents; all but one of them resided relatively far from the food rich

areas (Table 3), often in USDA designated food deserts (USDA ERS, 2015). These neighborhoods also have higher percentages of minority residents, are less affluent, and public transportation to the rest of Madison is limited (Madison Neighborhood Indicators, 2014). We recruited low-income and/or minority participants through referral by the directors of the community centers in these neighborhoods; help of the community centers' directors was necessary due to the lack of compensation for participants. This strategy resulted in ten interviews with participants with different levels of education and residing in different neighborhoods within Madison (Table 3).

The distribution of the consumers in this study intentionally does not reflect ethnic or income distribution of Madison. Madison's population is predominantly White (75.7%) with 7.3% African-Americans, 7.4% Asians and 6.8% Hispanics or Latinos. In addition, the median household income is \$53,933 (US Census Bureau, 2014) but over half of the participants had incomes lower than the lowest income quintile, which means they earned below \$20,260 per year. We have purposely oversampled minority and low-income residents because we were specifically interested in local food related experiences of people with demographic characteristics that were less likely to be associated with local food purchases (e.g. Brown, 2003; Payne, 2002).

The interviews were conducted between Fall 2013-Summer 2014 with one additional interview conducted in January 2015. The participants were interviewed in a private space in a public location that was convenient for them. Prior to the interview the participants were informed about the purpose of the study through a consent form. To avoid biasing the participants, they were told that the study was about food in general. Producers and sellers were asked about their businesses, sourcing, products, who purchased their products, who did not and

why, and their definitions, meanings, and importance of local food. Consumers were asked about their food preferences, cooking, shopping, and different interactions with local food including farmers' markets, gardens, and restaurants. Interview questions are recorded in the Appendix. At the end of the interviews, the participants were asked to fill a short demographic questionnaire.

The lead author and interviewer realized that her privilege could impede the conversation. To mitigate this, the researcher spent additional time to build trust with the low-income and/or minority participants before the interviews by attending events in the community centers and through additional conversations that were not recorded. In addition, the lead author recognized that the typical local food rhetoric could lack relevance to the low-income and/or minority participants. To this end, the researcher did not elicit the idea of local food and did not push the participants who did not know how to answer; instead, she focused on food procurement and preparation, during which the participants discussed their interactions with food in general.

In this study, we consider local food to be procured and prepared through both monetary transactions and non-monetary means. In addition, we want to make a case for including home cooked meals within the category of local food as well. We believe that if a meal made in a local restaurant with some local ingredients by a local chef is local, a meal made by a local resident from some ingredients that were grown by them or their family or purchased at the farmers' market should be considered local as well. While the consumers did not call these foods "local;" these forms of food procurement and preparation included shorter distances and fewer hands, and were often more direct than the local food discussed by the producers and sellers.

Audio recordings of the interviews were transcribed and coded by one of the authors who has experience with qualitative data using Saldana's (2009) coding manual as a guide; the coding

cycles, analytical memos, and findings were thoroughly discussed by both authors. We were specifically interested in how the producers and sellers explained the differences between customers' and non-customers' purchases or lack thereof of their products. For the consumers, we focused on their interactions with local food and food in general: how they viewed it and how they explained their behaviors. Our coding revealed the importance values for both groups; other variables of interest were demographics, knowledge, and context. We compare and contrast the perceptions of these variables between the two groups in the Results and Discussion section.

The relevant concepts for both groups and their implications are described below and illustrated by representative quotes. While the authors recognize the need for authenticity of the participants' narratives, given that a number of participants in this study were not native English speakers and some participants used colloquial speech, the quotes were edited for clarity. It is important to note that when counting how many participants gave a specific answer, often the numbers did not add up to the total number of the participants due to the fact that participants often named several options.

Results and Discussion

Producers and Sellers

Our coding revealed that the producers/sellers viewed attitudes as the most salient descriptor of customer and non-customer motivations; each participant mentioned at least one attitude to explain why people would purchase their product. The attitudes the producers'/sellers' perceived as facilitating purchases were interest in and positive attitudes towards their products and businesses, which were mentioned by all and six out of twelve participants, respectively. The most common product attributes were: product quality (six participants); followed by being local

(three participants); and healthy, organic, or of good value (two participants each). The producers who identified local as an important customer motivator also believed that their customers were interested in “knowing what was in their food” and were looking for information about products. In this way they distinguished their practices from others who they believed sold food without being able to account for the production process. While this implies that the producers/sellers viewed their customers as thoughtful and reflexive, we do not know whether that is actually true or whether this simply denotes what characteristics the producers/sellers valued in themselves and therefore used them to explain why customers preferred their products.

With regards to business attributes, all three retailers believed that service was important to their customers. Four other participants perceived their customers as people who wanted to support ethical aspects of their companies including being pro-social, agreeing with the company’s mission, and purchasing for a cause, as demonstrated by Elliot’s quote:

“I would say anyone who’s interested in healthy food and supporting a socially minded business ... because they can identify with what we’re doing and they like our mission.”

This quote interprets customers’ purchases as political actions; the producers/sellers viewed the purchases of their products as a boycott, i.e. purchasing to support a company one agrees with (Michelletti, 2008). This shows that the producers/sellers viewed themselves as virtuous; however, by promoting products and practices they viewed to be sustainable and ethical, the producers/sellers benefitted financially.

The producers/sellers perceived values, or “flawed” attitudes, as the major driver of lack of purchases. They did not believe that reasons not to purchase could be related to their products or businesses. To believe so would imply that some people could view their products as not good enough or their business as not ethical enough. These flawed attitudes the producers/sellers

described included not valuing one's own health and oneself in general, not caring for people, where their food was coming from, being inflexible or being too busy to learn about local food:

"I'd say probably the clearest way to put it is people [who don't purchase my products are people] that don't revere food. The people who don't [purchase my products], [they are] the majority of people who just buy because they need to eat. That in itself is a cultural aspect that we need to deal with in this country. That food is not revered. You should look at your plate and care about what's on that plate, why it's on that plate, who prepared it, who the farmer was. You have to understand this is your fuel." Jack

The fact that these flawed attitudes were more general and not just product specific indicates that local food has symbolic value; they suggest that the producers/sellers operated under self-serving bias. The use of "should" in Jack's quote denotes that purchases are a social norm; they are considered to be desirable and "normal." If they are viewed as such by others, the revenues of the producers/sellers increase.

The emphasis placed on monetary relationship is highlighted by the producers'/sellers' lack of recognition of growing, provisioning or cooking food for one's family or friends throughout the interviews as caring or virtuous. When Jack is talking about a food preparer, he is referring to a farmer who grew the produce and a paid chef in a restaurant who prepared it; none of the producers/sellers discussed home-growing and home-cooking in his responses. Those who grow their own food and cook at home but do not purchase from these producers/sellers thus belong to the category of non-customers and therefore are associated with the negative attitudes the producers/sellers described.

Like Leah's quote, Jack's quote discussed what the producers/sellers perceived to be food culture. Leah mentioned the culture of her customers, while Jack talked about the need to create a better culture around food. None of the leaders spoke of culture in terms of diversity due to different ethnicities or national origins. If the producers/sellers do not see the diversity of cultures, their food likely reflects their own culture, which is White, affluent, Midwestern.

The lack of perception of diversity is linked to not acknowledging the influence of demographic variables. When asked about who purchased their products and who did not, ten out of 12 participants either did not mention demographics characteristics or did not believe that they were linked to purchases. The participants who did not see demographic characteristics as influential included four participants who did not mention a single demographic variable and six participants who mentioned two or more demographic variables but claimed that they sold to a broad cross-section of customers, as illustrated by a quote from Leah:

“But the truth of the matter is we get all sorts of people here. Really it’s turned out to be a male/female 50:50, and all walks of life. ... We have really grown to see is that the culture of [those who appreciate our product] that land in our yard are from all walks of life: ethnicities, sex, age, income level. It’s been very wide.”

While Leah’s quote is representative in that it represents a perception of being frequented by a variety of customers, she was the only producer to include the word “ethnicity” and “income.” Nathan and Will did not discuss demographic characteristics either but mentioned that their location determined, albeit not exclusively, who frequented their business. While they both indicated that some people traveled to their locations from further away, the composition of the neighborhood likely influenced whom they viewed as their customers:

“I think our community is all the people that live and work in the immediate vicinity of our stores. I think we draw from fairly small radius around each of the places and they are anything from the back door guys who live in the house behind us to the family that are both professors at the university to the architects and real estate people who hang out at our places all day long using it as their office to the kid... [interrupted].” Nathan

In the quote above while Nathan did not note the demographic composition of his customers, he chose to name people with prestigious occupations as his visitors. These people likely represented the neighborhoods he was located in: three of his venues were located close to the university and downtown offices. Through portraying his customers as highly educated and successful, he portrayed his place as a space desirable for more affluent people.

While we do not have actual information about the demographics of the producers'/sellers' customers, we do know that even the DCFM customers are Whiter and more affluent than Madison (Zepeda & Carroll, 2016). The notion that the producers'/sellers' clientele is "everyone" is therefore a curious one. Only three participants said they conducted a survey of some of their customers, how then do the participants know what they know? None of the participants oversaw all their sales; it is therefore unlikely that they had an accurate idea of the demographic breakdown of the people who purchased their products.

It is possible that the participants compared their clientele to the demographics of the neighborhoods they were located in. Alkon & McCullen (2012) described a similar phenomenon at two farmers' markets in California: interviews with farmers' market managers, vendors and customers revealed that the participants believed that the market reflected the demographics of their town. However, when asked about the ethnic distribution of the population, they grossly underestimated the town's non-White population. The perception of their city thus allowed them to view the overly White farmers' market as "normal." Given that all of the producers/sellers in this study were located in neighborhoods that were on average Whiter and more affluent than the rest of Madison, it is possible that their clientele actually represented the neighborhood they were located in but not necessarily Madison as a whole. Alternately, the demographic composition of their neighborhood could have led to their misconceptions about overall Madison demographics.

Aside from the flawed attitudes attributed to non-customers, our coding revealed that seven of the 12 participants discussed the prices of their products in relation to their non-customers. This was expressed in three different ways: two participants argued that people did not purchase from them because they perceived the prices of their products as too high, two participants mentioned their products were expensive products but justified the price by

explaining their methods of production, and two participants believed that people who did not purchase from them valued cheapness over any other aspects of a product. Samantha thought that big families might avoid her store due to the cost associated with feeding a larger family.

Will discussed strategies people employed to overcome income issues, thus implying that values can overcome income limitations:

“We do have people who are on a very fixed income and have to be extremely careful with how they spend their money and they’ll shop the discount bins and peruse and they’ll buy in bulk to save money and it’s more work, but there are a number of people who place a lot of value on that and do that.”

While the quote acknowledges that Will perceived the importance of fixed income, the “right” values had the power to overcome income limitations. Overall, the producers’/sellers’ views of price and attribution of purchases of their “better” products to individual choice implies that education would lead to the purchase of these “better” products from these producers/sellers.

The last variable mentioned by the producers/sellers was convenience. While five producers mentioned it, two viewed it as possibly inhibiting purchases and three viewed it as facilitating purchases. The two farmers perceived convenience as preventing CSA purchases; their views are corroborated in literature (Zepeda & Leviten-Reid, 2004). Interestingly, three participants viewed convenience as facilitating purchases. Jonathan, Will, and Samantha perceived that despite not having the “right” values, some of their customers purchased their products because they lived close to their location. Given that the three producers/sellers were located in White, affluent neighborhoods, this group of convenience-driven customers was still likely to reflect the neighborhood’s demographics. The perceived role of convenience is highlighted in the following quote:

“There are people who, they just want some food, they don’t care as much as a lot of our shoppers do about it being organic, natural, or local, but we’re two blocks away, and so... Yeah,

they'll shop there. But if a different store were two blocks away, they'd be shopping there instead." Will

Will's quote highlights his belief that customers who shop for convenience are less loyal than those who shop for the "right" reasons. This is similar to the views of Samantha and Jonathan, who also indicated that some of their customers only purchased their products because it was convenient for them. The three producers/sellers said they wanted to educate those "accidental" customers about the importance of local food, hoping to instill in them other local food behaviors and in turn, loyalty to their products:

"There's a whole bunch of people who shop here because we're next door, or just shop here because they need their milk and eggs and maybe don't care, or aren't paying attention to local foods or to where that food may be coming from and I think that's our opportunity to help them see and appreciate when they're just throwing things in the cart and just you know, throwing them in the oven at home, that there is a story behind those."

In addition, four other producers/sellers mentioned education as a strategy to bring more people to purchase their products. In this way, the producers/sellers reinforced two ideas: (1) purchases of local food are the "right" behaviors and (2) education will instill appropriate attitudes, which they viewed as valuing the products they sold and the ethics of their businesses. Their rhetoric implied that these "right" attitudes would in turn result in more purchases; at the same time, they did not perceive how demographics might influence attitudes or how context could facilitate or prevent behaviors.

Consumers

Coding for local food behaviors revealed that only one of the consumers likely had experiences with the venues or products of the producers/sellers in this study and another one occasionally shopped for seafood at Samantha's store. This confirms that this group of consumers can be considered to be non-customers of the majority of the producers/sellers and we

can therefore compare and contrast their narratives with the producers'/sellers' perceptions about their non-customers. The only exception is Grant, who while low-income, he expressed his privilege and affiliation with local food producers and sellers throughout his interview. Grant's rhetoric is highlighted throughout the rest of this section.

All the consumers indicated that they procured and prepared local foods through both monetary and non-monetary transactions. While nine participants out of ten visited or used to visit the Dane County Farmers' Market (DCFM) in downtown Madison, their visits were infrequent and mostly described as "having something to do on a Saturday" rather than a regular shopping trip. Two participants purchased meat from a local farm. Four participants mentioned infrequently visiting a restaurant that the researchers considered a local restaurant due to their use of local food and/or production of value-added products. Grace also reported attending a local food event that featured a number of popular restaurants, but she did not name any of them.

However, the participants appeared to enjoy gardening and cooking. Four consumers procured food from their gardens: two participants reported having a garden and two others helped in the gardens of their relatives. Those four participants indicated that the garden was their major source of produce; they usually froze or stored produce to last them through the winter. Four other participants had a garden in recent years, and Grace indicated a desire to have a garden in which she could work with her granddaughters. Eight out of ten participants cooked at least several times per week; two participants enjoyed home-cooked meals shared by their family members.

We found that the consumers described their behaviors as determined by their values and influenced by their demographics, knowledge, and context. In this text we will therefore describe the five values we found to be most common: preference for (1) fresh and healthy food; (2)

commensality; (3) culturally appropriate products; (4) affordability; and (5) convenience. We then discuss how the behaviors stemming from these values are affected by the rest of the variables.

The participants overall valued fresh and healthy food, which they believed they could obtain from their gardens, the farmers' market, and grocery stores to prepare at home. In addition, four consumers valued knowing what was in their food. However, this "knowing" was not linked to purchases from farmers or eating in restaurants, as the producers/sellers ascribed to their customers' motivation. Instead of trusting others, they indicated that they knew what was in their food when they grew or cooked the food themselves:

"[Gardening is important to us] because we know what goes into it. I hear stories and I read stories in the paper that a lot of pesticides and things like that go into a lot of the food that's [inaudible] by the time it's shipped. ... At least I know what's in what we have in our garden." Antonio

This implies that producers/sellers did not have an accurate perception of their non-customers: the same values that the producers/sellers linked to purchases of their products were prominent in the consumers' explanations of their gardening and cooking behaviors. An implication for the local food movement is that rather than driving local food through purchases, they could equally try to promote gardening and cooking at home.

Commensality, or cooking for and with others, including family, friends, and even strangers was important to the participants, as Sasha, who regularly cooks a community meal at a community center, described:

"And when you do soul food, soul food is food that you just can't cook like any other, it has to come from the heart and what you're feeling inside of you and all your love goes into your food. That makes it good. And people love [it], when you see people sitting by, enjoying the food that you prepared, and you see them smiling and saying the food is good, you did something great."

Commensality is a feature of home cooking that is not prominent in restaurants that value professionalism (Krautkammer, 2007). The participants of this study would agree with this; many believed that cooking and eating together facilitated community. This rhetoric was missing from the producers'/sellers' narratives; their strong interest in supporting their community was mostly connected to economic support but did not appear to consider the social nature of their community as important (Reznickova & Zepeda, 2016). This neglect of social community is relevant to those who view local food as facilitating social ties (Pole & Gray, 2013). An interesting question then would be whether these consumers create a community around commensality and what the benefits of this community were.

Both preference for fresh, healthy food and commensality appear to stem from the participants' childhoods: they discussed preparing food with their family or being surrounded by fresh produce when asked about their favorite meals, and their experiences with cooking and gardening. These experiences also provided them with knowledge of food preparation: they learned about food from their parents, grandparents, and other important figures of their lives. Sofia illustrated how important the connections were between food and family in her description of learning to cook from her grandmother:

“Me, I was not interested too much in the play with people and outside in the street or something. I preferred staying with my grandma in the kitchen. ‘And grandma, what are you putting in this?’ ‘Oh I put in the tomatillos for the [inaudible].’ ‘And why are you putting it in this?’ ‘Oh, because for the good seasonings is the onions and garlic.’ And she used the [traditional stone mortar and pestle], they don’t have blenders, she made it in this one. ‘Grandma, what are you putting in?’ Every time she says to me: ‘The best for cooking is in everything cooked, in a recipe, is onion, garlic, and salt.’ This is the best. This is how I remember.”

All but two participants valued culturally appropriate foods and purchased some of their food in ethnic and/or specialty stores. This can be linked to demographics, specifically the ethnic diversity of our sample: only two of the participants self-identified as White/African-American

and White and six of the participants indicated that they did not grow up in Madison. The three Asian participants all noted that their food is different from what they called “Americanized” foods such as pizza, pasta, and fried chicken.

The rest of the participants enjoyed cooking meals they were comfortable with. Despite frequenting a number of ethnic and specialty stores in Madison, seven participants said they or their friends experienced difficulty finding everything they sought. The participants thus experienced a non-facilitating context, which they overcame using alternative strategies including having relatives send them items from abroad, going to a larger city to find foods, or asking a friend who runs a specialty store for a special order. Sasha described the difficulties of finding foods that were important to her, contrasting them to local foods and emphasizing how her foods were not available or even valued:

“But [in] Madison [they] don’t carry a lot of country food. They carry a lot of, like you say, local food, but they don’t carry the foods from the South. And I’d be looking for a lot of foods from the South, [for instance greens], they’ve got the greens, but they don’t [have] what I’m looking for. I’d be looking for pig feet but you might have to go to certain stores to find it because not all stores carry it. Like [name of store] don’t carry it: the pig feets and the pig tails. And a lot of people say ‘Whew, that’s nasty.’”

Second, the immigrants identified cultural barriers to local food markets. Antonio and Riya discussed differences in venues between local food markets in Madison and in their home countries. Antonio stated that local farmers’ market and a mobile market that brought fresh produce to the food desert neighborhoods were not comfortable for Hispanics. The farmers’ market did not have the products and atmosphere they were familiar with and the mobile market was “too clean” so they did not trust it. Riya focused on the lack of accessibility and affordability of local markets; she used to frequent markets that were open all day every day with prices that were lower than the supermarket. Suab brought up issues of language barrier; a lot of elders in her community did not speak English and did not feel comfortable at a farmers’ market. It

therefore appears that the local food context was perceived by the participants as preventing them and others from accessing fresh, local food.

Another important cultural aspect of local food that emerged from the interviews was the connection between some cultures and gardening. Both Cai and Suab talked about gardening being the “traditional” way of life for their parents. This was consistent with the views of Lis, an Asian farmer in this study who said he wanted to promote traditional ways of farming among the youth of his community. While Suab never brought up local food and did not know how to answer questions about local food, she talked at length about the health of her community, which she viewed largely connected to their traditional lifestyle of gardening and producing their own food:

“Now we’re working on having our own farmers’ market where the kids can be involved and where those families where they can actually grow and maybe make a little income to buy, or to eat ... [I am] working with elders and how in this area we have a lot of seniors who need, who are disabled and need handicap accessibility for those and how we had to, we had to make sure we had enough raised beds for those who can’t bend over. And the more I see them, and the more how they stress to us, because I take care of the garden stuff here, they want to garden, because I think for me, I see it as a way of healing for individuals and it’s like how my mom, gardening is a way of life also, you know?”

Our results imply that participants’ ethnicity and where they came from influenced their food preferences; demographics thus influenced attitudes, which in turn were linked to both purchasing and non-monetary habits. The cultural preferences stand in direct contrast to the producers/sellers who did not acknowledge culture as important in determining local food purchases; to them, culture referred to “their” culture, not a cultural diversity of consumers and products. In addition to not being able to find culturally appropriate foods and describing the food offered by the majority of the producers/sellers as “Americanized,” some of the participants identified cultural barriers at local food venues. For local food to be food for all, it is necessary that both the foods offered and the venues they are offered at reflect cultural diversity.

Affordability emerged as an important theme all participants but Grant. This could be a result of the participants' income: six out of ten participants indicated their household income was in the lowest household quintile. The participants with a higher household income also reported having larger households, which means that their income was still limited. The participants indicated that they were looking for places that they thought were "cheaper." The participants habitually shopped at a regional chain store that advertised itself as being known for its low prices that were "lower than national chains" and being a "one-stop, convenient, grocery shopping destination." Several participants mentioned that they viewed another regional chain store that advertised itself as "having everyday low prices" and "fantastic weekly specials" as more expensive, thus preventing them from shopping there, which implies that they had some knowledge of prices and sales. In contrast to the venues frequented by the consumers, none of the retailers in our study advertise themselves as "cheap." In fact, all three retailers noted that they were more expensive than the specific stores named by the consumers, which suggests that the consumers would not view them as affordable.

As additional evidence that the participants viewed purchases of local food as unaffordable, five participants mentioned that fresh, good looking, organic and/or local vegetables were more expensive and four participants brought up the cost of the DCFM. All participants who went to local restaurants said they could not afford to do so regularly. This implies that the prices of local food are an actual barrier preventing these consumers from purchasing local food products from the producers/sellers in this study rather than preference for cheap food implied by the producers/sellers.

Despite the overall concern with affordability, Cai's and Grant's rhetoric corresponded to the views of producers/sellers. One explanation for this is that they are similar to the

producers/sellers. Grant is White and Cai is ethnically Asian, but also a first generation American who described himself as “Americanized.” Cai said he regularly helped his parents sell produce at a small town farmers’ market. This experience as a producer/seller could be why his perception is similar to the producer/sellers in that the food he was selling was not expensive. Rather, he thought that those who did not purchase it suffered from the “wrong” perception that local food was more expensive.

On the other hand, Grant believed that buying local and organic food was a matter of one’s priorities, rather than being about cost. He rationalized that he could afford “better” food because he made it a priority, choosing “better” food over having a car. Note that Grant could “afford” to not have a car because he was the only participant who lived in a central part of Madison. Grant characterized his choices as virtuous:

“I like to be a shining example of eating well and having a good time and being so poor, I’m the most virtuous poor man you know, and I eat at least fifty percent organic, I have a sense of priorities about how I spent my money, I couldn’t afford to live here if I had a car, I don’t have a car, but I eat real real[ly] well.”

Grant was the one consumer that indicated shopping at Will’s store; both Grant and Will expressed similar opinions about the “virtuousness” of shopping for local food. In this way, Grant is an example of the low-income customer Will was talking about; he is the customer who follows his priorities and overcomes obstacles to make the “right choice.” While he did not say it directly, he implied that those who did not purchase at Will’s store were less virtuous and did not have the “right” sense of priorities. However, it is important to acknowledge other privilege evident from Grant’s discourse, including social ties to local producers and sellers. This privilege, similar to that of the producers/sellers of this study, is likely a result of his demographic characteristics: he was born in the Midwest, has extensive experience with Italian cooking and organic farming, and his rhetoric confirmed that he was comfortable discussing

local food and sustainability. Such privilege did not emerge from the transcripts of other low-income participants.

Last, while we found that convenience was mentioned often, it did not seem to be as important to the consumers in this study. Despite six participants suggesting that they frequented stores that were closest or most convenient for them, the majority of participants used their own cars to travel. This is consistent with other studies that indicated urban and rural poor traveled far for affordable food they wanted (Alkon et al., 2013; Zepeda et al., 2015). However, Antonio noted that access to cars was not universal in his neighborhood:

“A lot of people don’t drive in this community and the bus really does not drop them off at the store, there’s a lot of walking involved and a lot of carrying of those bags so it’s a huge task for them and a lot of people don’t go to the [name of a store] because they feel it’s a higher end and they end up spending more money and they just can’t afford that so they don’t go down to that side of the city.”

Antonio, Suab and Mariah mentioned that access in terms of cars, buses, social ties, and cost could be a problem for others in their communities. Access was an issue for frequenting the Dane County Farmers’ Market (DCFM): while nine of the participants visited the DCFM sometime during their life in Madison, they believed that the location was not convenient and they preferred not to spend time adding another shopping venue to their list. The participants indicated that they preferred spending time with their family or that they worked on Saturdays. With respect to convenience, parking and transportation challenges for those who were older and/or disabled were particularly important issues. With poor local bus connections and crowds, it was difficult for some participants to access stores and DCFM.

It is interesting that the participants did not discuss other, smaller markets dispersed around the city that were much closer to them. It is possible they were unaware of these markets: the markets are less well known and open for two to three hours one day a week. It might also be

that given that the participants identified entertainment and variety as positive features of the DCFM, they did not shop at the smaller farmers' markets because they lack entertainment and have so few vendors. Another possibility is that the participants internalized the idea that the DCFM, a mostly White farmers' market, is the best farmers' market. The reasons for choosing one market over others would be an interesting research question for future inquiry.

Overall, we found that the majority of the ten consumers were non-customers of the producers/sellers in this study, with the exception of Grant who not only could be considered a customer but his rhetoric matched the producers/sellers. The consumers perceived their behaviors as determined by their values, specifically their preference for fresh and healthy food, commensality, cultural appropriateness, affordability, and partially, convenience. Those values were linked to their demographics and experiences growing up. However, the local food context, namely the lack of culturally appropriate and affordable local food products, prevented purchases and led to gardening and cooking with and for friends and family.

Conclusion

In this case study we found differences between the producers'/sellers' perceptions of the purchases or lack thereof of their products and the local residents' perceptions of their own local food related behaviors. The producers/sellers elicited "right" and "wrong" values as the major reasons and did not recognize the diversity of cultures within Madison nor that income could limit consumer choices. This stands in contrast with the perceptions of low-income and/or minority residents who did not purchase products of the producers and sellers in this study but gardened and cooked at home. These local residents valued fresh and healthy food and eating with others, but they did not purchase local food because they did not perceive it to be culturally

appropriate or affordable. The results of our study have a number of policy implications based on the value-laden portrayal of the local food (non-)consumer and the perceptions of the low-income, minority participants.

The rhetoric focusing on values is similar to the rhetoric of farmers' markets' and CSA managers, which is considered to be exclusionary (Alkon & McCullen, 2011; Guthman, 2008b). While we included a variety of producers and sellers, it appears that the self-identification with local food appears to give them symbolic value that governs the perceptions of why people "should" buy from them. By describing purchases in their venues as governed by the "right" values and imparting negative judgment on the "others" who did not purchase their products, the producers/sellers implied that local food purchases were virtuous.

The producers'/sellers' viewpoint could be influenced by the prevalence of the political consumption discourse in local food documentaries, books, and media (e.g. Pearlstein & Kenner, 2006; Pollan, 2006). This discourse focuses on equating knowledge with consumer behavior, which it views as politicized (Guthman, 2008c). While we agree that political consumption is an important piece of civic participation (Micheletti, 2008), we showed that it could also lead to imparting negative judgment onto people who are not perceived as consuming politically. As a result of not purchasing the "right" food, i.e. the culturally White foods produced and sold by the producers in this study, the consumers in this study could be viewed as not caring about what people "should" care about. Charlotte Biltekoff (2013) described similar tensions between the middle-class Whites and recent immigrants in the early 20th century. The former group assigned negative qualities to the latter group because they viewed them as being "wrong" due to not eating according to the newly drafted nutritional guidelines. This discourse is harmful in that it creates a divide between culturally diverse populations.

Our study therefore raises several questions: Why is the marketplace the only valid place for local food consumption? Who determines what local food is? If local food purchases are viewed as political consumption, why is growing food at home not viewed that way? If restaurant owners using locally grown produce are viewed as “making the right” choices, why is using the same ingredients to cook at home not viewed as such?

The local food leaders’ perceptions that knowledge leads to attitudes, which turn into behaviors follows the archaic Knowledge-Attitude-Behavior model that has long been discounted in psychology (Kollmuss & Agyeman, 2002). Such model may be politically convenient because it allows to not take into account the realities of class and race. Instead of understanding behavior within the societal context, it implies that behavior is a personal responsibility that can be supported by education. The producers’ and sellers’ perceptions thus imply that an appropriate policy would consist of implementing an educational program to eliminate the “wrong” attitudes of the poor and minorities to encourage them to buy local food. Education and exposure were used by White activists who advocated for urban agriculture in inner city neighborhoods of New Orleans (Kato & McKinney, 2015) and in California (Guthman, 2008a), but even by African-Americans who ran the failed mobile market in Chicago (Zepeda & Reznickova, 2013). More often than not, these “missionary” projects suffered from community indifference and failed due to the activists’ lack of knowledge of these communities’ culture and the challenges they faced (Guthman, 2008a), which we believe would be the result for the local residents in this case as well.

Instead of education, recognizing these communities’ ways of procuring and preparing food, as well as the importance of a facilitating context, i.e. a marketplace where they could obtain culturally appropriate and affordable products could bridge the divide of the local food

movement. To be able to offer culturally appropriate food, the local food movement could for instance encourage and welcome minority farmers and business owners to bring their knowledge and traditional ways of food production to the table. A successful model of this is the mobile market and farmers' market run by the Regional Environmental Council in Worcester, Massachusetts that subsidizes produce grown by immigrant farmers and sells it to an immigrant community (Reznickova & Zepeda, 2016).

The mobile market and farmers' market in Worcester are also described by their managers as successful because they offer a half-off discount for their products. This model of matching what EBT holders spend on fruits and vegetables at a farmers' market, thus doubling their purchasing power, is replicated in a number of different locations under different names and is viewed as essential in increasing participation of EBT holders in local markets (Zepeda & Reznickova, 2016). Funding for such a project on the national scale could help low-income consumers access fresh foods while also increasing farmers' revenues by bringing customers who could not otherwise purchase their products. However, it is important to note that more research into such arrangements is necessary to evaluate their success.

While our study is limited to one location and twenty-two participants, we have highlighted an important issue of differences between perceptions of local food producers/sellers and experiences of low-income and/or minority consumers. However, it is important to note that Madison, Wisconsin is predominantly White, which could have influenced how local food producers/sellers anchored the demographics of their clientele. A future study could therefore assess whether the perceptions of local food customers by local food leaders are more accurate in local food spaces in more diverse regions.

In addition, we have used the products the producers/sellers sell as a proxy for local food. It is possible that if these producers/sellers were asked about their perceptions of people who purchase local food in general and people who do not, their answers would be different. However, despite acknowledging that they could be more expensive than other food venues, the producers/sellers in this study still did not recognize affordability as an issue. It is therefore unlikely that they would recognize it as an issue in cheaper venues, for instance at farmers' markets.

Last, social desirability bias could have played some role in directing answers in both groups. On the producers' and sellers' side, they might have assumed that an academic with an interest in local food supported their views, on the consumers' side, it is possible that the demographic differences between the researcher and the participants created distance and hindered the conversation (Seidman, 2013). The interviews and the general demeanor of the participants suggest that they felt free to discuss what they wanted and so it appears this bias was minimized. In addition, even if the producers felt social desirability bias, it is likely that they would feel similarly when talking to other people involved with local food. If that was the case, their responses likely indicated how and what they communicated with others.

In the end, we found that the "education" promoted by local food leaders is perhaps targeted in the wrong direction. Instead of educating consumers about local food, local food leaders need to understand that some local food consumers are different than they are: they have different cultures, eat different foods, and have different abilities to access and afford mainstream local food, but they also have very strong ties to food production, provisioning and preparation. Many of these consumers had much shorter food chains, much more direct connection to food than the "caring" local food customers described by the producers/sellers in

this study, but their experiences were not recognized because these activities were not monetized (Nelson, 1993) and because their communities were marginalized.

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Article 2: Producing for the Right Reasons: A Case Study of Local Food Production Community in Madison, Wisconsin

Abstract

Consumption communities explain how consumers of a specific brand relate to each other; they have benefits for the brand, including increased brand loyalty, recruitment of new consumers, as well as psychosocial benefits to the consumer. In this case study, we suggest that a similar community exists for producers organized around local food. We interview 12 farmers, value-added producers, restaurant owners, and retailers based in Madison, Wisconsin and find evidence of a production community: consciousness of a kind outlines group boundaries, rituals and traditions propagate group values, and moral obligation directs help to other members of the community. The participants distinguish their group from other producers and sellers based on business attributes, practices and personal values; this has implications for community inclusion and exclusion. In addition, the participants' narratives of sourcing indicate that sustainability is compromised by price, consistency of supply, and the desire to support others who are similar to the in-group.

Introduction

Building on Veblen's (1899) discussion of social class and conspicuous consumption, Boorstin (1973) described relationships between consumers as "invisible new communities ... created and preserved by how and what men consumed." These views move consumption away from an individual towards the collective; consumers related to each other through the products they consumed. Consumption communities introduced a new framework to understand and

promote brand loyalty (McAlexander et al., 2002), brand use (Muniz & Schau, 2005), and participation in brand innovation processes (Fuller et al., 2008). In the past fifty years, consumers of well-known, often national brands or popular culture have been at the center of consumption community research, limiting consumption community framework to relationships between multiple consumers and one producer.

We propose applying the concept of consumption community to products from different producers and sellers. Instead of multiple consumers purchasing a specific brand from one producer, consumers interact with multiple producers of products with a common characteristic. We apply this model to local food because different local food products are produced by a number of actors. We examine whether these producers and sellers feel a parallel kinship similar to that of consumers within a consumption community. In Boorstin's words, we ask whether invisible new communities can be created by how and what (wo)men produce?

The existence of production community, i.e. a community centered on production/selling of a specific type of product, has numerous implications for both the product and its producers and sellers. Drawing from consumer research (McAlexander et al., 2002; Muniz & Schau, 2005), if there indeed is a production community, belonging to one could have implications for loyalty to the product or recruitment and helping new producers and sellers. This would imply that this community could facilitate an increased supply of and commitment to local food. At the same time, a production community could have a number of drawbacks. Consumption community literature shows that those communities can position themselves against "others" whom they view as not legitimate (Muniz and O'Guinn, 2001) and community norms can also create pressure and turn members away (Algesheimer et al., 2005). An implication is that the local food

production community could turn into an exclusive group with limited membership, thus weakening inclusion in the local food movement.

The purpose of this study is to define a production community and examine if local food producers and sellers can be characterized as sharing the same system of ideas and behaviors. To do so, we employ the theoretical framework from the consumption community literature and use local food producers and sellers in Madison, Wisconsin as a case study. This site was selected because of its concentration of local food producers and sellers.

To demonstrate the application of a production community to local food, we examine the direct and indirect networks among 12 participants involved in producing and selling local food in Madison, Wisconsin. They include three farmers, three value-added producers, three restaurant owners, and three retailers. Our analysis of interviews examines whether the three determinants of consumption community, consciousness of a kind, rituals and traditions surrounding product use, and a sense of moral obligation, emerge. These three criteria characterize a production community in that they outline its culture and show how the culture is propagated, determine the boundaries between who participates and who does not, and explain whether and how members help each other and the brand (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001).

This study contributes to the consumer studies literature by describing a new kind of community, a production community, which complements the consumption community literature. We argue that producers of similar products can have relationships with each other, which has implications for product supply and the culture of brands. This approach can be utilized to further study loyalty to production of ethical brands and how to promote collaboration in the marketplace to promote greater sustainability. This case study also has implications for advocates of local food who would like to see the community being inclusive (Allen, 1999;

DeLind, 2011; Feenstra, 1997). Applying the consumption community framework, we identify some potential aspects of a local food production community, including possible issues of commitment to sustainable values, potential boundaries to entry, and member exclusion.

Literature Review

The theoretical framework of a consumption community is rooted in the symbolic meaning of products. The 20th century saw the disappearance of purely geographical, rural communities (Tonnies, 1887); at the same time, a new kind of community emerged. Rather than being based on physical proximity, this community had psychological foundations, relying on perception of similarity between members (Anderson, 1983). An application of this idea is that products carry symbolic meanings: they can become a part of one's identity (Kleine et al., 1993) and signal social status (Levy, 1959) and cultural capital (Holt, 1996). Since products signal specific consumer attributes, it follows that consumers can perceive others who use a specific product to be similar to them (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001).

Consumption communities have many advantages to the brand and the consumer. Consumers who feel they belong to a consumption community are more loyal to their brands (McAlexander et al., 2002), create and increase product value (Schau et al., 2009), participate in the product innovation process (Fuller et al., 2008), and recruit more consumers (Muniz and Schau, 2005), thus increasing revenues to the brand. Advantages to consumers themselves include product use guidance from other members (Muniz & O'Guinn, 2001), as well as satisfaction of their psychological and socio-cultural needs (Fournier, 1998). However, consumption communities can have a dark side: they can recruit new consumers selectively

(Muniz & O’Guinn, 2001) or create social norms that turn members away (Algesheimer et al., 2005). Thus, they can also function to decrease the product’s consumer base.

Consumption communities can focus on brands (e.g. Muniz & O’Guinn, 2002), activities (e.g. Cova & Cova, 2002) and ideologies (e.g. Schouten & McAlexander, 1995). The majority of consumption community literature focuses on national products, including luxury products such as Apple (Muniz & Schau, 2005) or Harley Davidson motorcycles (McAlexander & Schouten, 1998) and fandoms, including Star Trek (Kozinets, 2001) and Xena, the Warrior Princess (Schau et al., 2009), as well as processed foods, like Nutella (Cova & Pace, 2006). Some literature examines alternative or “anti-market” consumption communities. These include lifestyle subcultures such as punk rockers (Hebdige, 1979), anti-consumption movements (Kozinets & Handelman, 2004) and anti-corporate communities (Thompson & Arsel, 2004), communities around products consumed for political reasons, so called “polit-brands” (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2004), and the bartering community at Burning Man (Kozinets, 2002). Literature on sustainable products, such as the case of local food examined in this study, is lacking.

While the examined products vary across studies, the study participants are always consumers. The studies do not examine how producers of similar products interact, perhaps due to the fact that the product at the center of these studies is often a single brand or single producer. An exception to this is Thompson and Arsel’s (2004) study of consumers of local coffee shops, in which a range of products and services in different coffee shops are considered. However, even in this study, no attention is paid to how the coffee shop owners view each other.

Thomas et al. (2013) argue that producers have a role in co-creating the culture of the brand but that does not necessarily imply that they belong to the consumption community or that they create a community of their own. What is new in our study is that we focus on finding a

community among producers and sellers of local food. Given the competition in the marketplace, we would not expect a community. If there is one, what is its culture and social norms? How is it delineated? What are the implications for inclusiveness of members, collaborations, and the culture of the product?

Local food is an appropriate subject for a case study because it is not produced by a single company, but produced and sold by a number of independent producers and sellers in different venues. Local food has been successful in the market as demonstrated by increased venues and sales. The number of farmers' markets increased from 1,755 to between 8,284 in the past 20 years (USDA ERS, 2014), the number of Community Supported Agriculture farms (CSA) increased from two in 1986 to over 12,000 in 2012 (McFadden, 2004; USDA NASS, 2012) and in 2012, local food sales were estimated at \$6.1 billion (Low et al., 2015). However, local food is no longer limited to fresh fruits and vegetables purchased at direct-to-consumer venues. It can be found among value-added products, in retail and in hospitality businesses; 80% of local food sales come from intermediate market channels (Low et al., 2015). This implies that a possible production community could include a number of different actors: farmers, value-added producers, food service business owners, and retailers.

The case study of a local food community is interesting because despite being promoted by writers (e.g. Pollan, 2006), documentaries (e.g. Pearlstein & Kenner, 2008), chefs such as Alice Waters, and "Buy [fill in a region], Buy local!" marketing campaigns (Food Routes, n.d.), local food does not have a specific definition (USDA, n.d.) and different people view its definition differently (Eriksen, 2013). This introduces an interesting issue for the potential community: if local food is not defined, how do we know whether products sold are local? If there is a community among producers and sellers of local food, how do members decide who

belongs to the community and who does not? To be able to answer this, we have to find and define a production community. Our research question therefore is:

RQ: Is there a production community in Madison, Wisconsin among local food producers and sellers?

To demonstrate the existence of such community between producers and sellers of local food, we need to show that

- a. the participants share consciousness of a kind;
- b. rituals and traditions, and
- c. moral obligation as outlined by the framework of consumption communities.

Proposed by Muniz and O’Guinn (2001), these three characteristics not only determine the presence of a community, they are also essential for understanding group culture. Specifically, they explain how members relate to each other while distinguishing themselves from outsiders, how they use the product, and whether and how they demonstrate their moral obligation.

Consciousness of a kind is a feeling of a collective self; it requires that members relate to each other and believe each other to be alike (O’Guinn & Muniz, 2004a), while at the same time they feel separated from others (Gusfield, 1978). Members of the community distinguish themselves from users of other brands but also from those who simply “use” the brand rather than love it and appreciate it as the “true” members do (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2013).

Consciousness of a kind can be a double-edged sword. On the one hand, it strengthens one’s ties

to the group, which can result in greater brand loyalty and help other users (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2001). On the other hand, it can promote exclusion and elitism.

In consumption community literature, rituals and traditions consist of sharing product history, knowledge about the product, and experiences with the product (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2013). Rituals and traditions are often depicted in participant narratives by product knowledge and use that participants share with others. This propagates collective consciousness and social norms among the consumption community promoting “correct” product use (Muniz & O’Guinn, 2001).

The last consumption community determinant is feeling moral obligation towards each other and the brand. Obligation is not a strong feature in the consumption community literature; Muniz and O’Guinn (2001) compare them to Janowitz’s (1952) communities of limited liability in urban neighborhoods. These communities represent people with common goals to attract resources to their neighborhoods, but member obligation is limited. We believe that findings of moral obligation in the literature have been limited for two reasons. First, consumption community studies are often netnographies; they consist of content analysis of online articles and discussion forums. In such environments, members do not have the opportunity to interact face-to-face, so helping each other may not be possible or obvious to the researcher. Second, with a few exceptions discussed above, the majority of consumption community studies do not include a brand that promotes moral obligation. We argue that moral obligation could be greater or have more dimensions in a community around a brand that is associated with pro-environmental or pro-social consumption, such as local food.

Muniz and O’Guinn’s (2013) examples of moral obligation include being faithful to the brand, recruitment and integration of new members, and assisting others with the use of brand or

on other occasions. This implies that moral obligation is an important dimension for growth of the brand as members work to find new consumers of the brand. In the case of producers, moral obligation is an interesting dimension given market competition. If producers feel moral obligation toward each other, this theoretical framework would imply that there could be greater cooperation among producers, including assistance to those entering the market.

Methods

To show whether all three components of a consumption community exist for a local food production community, we examine the case of Madison, Wisconsin. With a population of 234,344 (US Census Bureau, 2014), it is a mid-sized city in the Midwestern United States where local food is featured very prominently. Venues include a summer farmers' market on the Capital Square (Dane County Farmers' Market, n.d.), twelve other farmers' markets within the city and dozens in the county outside the city, several food cooperatives, an urban CSA farm, two Slow Food chapters, dozens of Farm-to-Table restaurants, many artisanal food shops, and many local breweries. Given this prevalence of local food, Madison is an appropriate site to study local food.

To examine whether Madison can be characterized as a local food production community, we selected participants who were engaged in producing or selling local food in the city (Table 2). We recruited three participants each from farmers, value-added producers, restaurants, and retail, for a total of 12 participants. Since we were interested in exploring the boundaries of this community, we tried to capture the diversity of businesses, including product characteristics, sourcing, size and type of business, and distribution distance. While the study uses a convenience sample, the lead author had lived and worked in Madison three years prior to

collecting data for this study and selected participants to represent a variety of products and venues. So while the farmers are all vegetable farmers, they sell their produce at different venues. The value-added producers have three very different products: a luxury item, a beverage and a staple food, and they vary in their involvement with local farmers and in their distribution distance. The restaurant owners and retailers vary in the size of their business and in how many local food products they use.

The participant characteristics are reported in Table 2. The participants' identity is protected; instead of their name or the name of their business we use an alias with an abbreviation consisting of letters describing the business type followed by a number to distinguish between participants of the same business type. The following are the letter abbreviations: FA for farmers, VA for value-added producers, RE for restaurants and other food service businesses, and RT for retailers.

To study the application of a production community we use two approaches: an online search and in-depth interviews. The purpose of the online search was to investigate whether a production community existed in terms of interactions among the participants of this study. Did they interact with each other directly or could they potentially interact through their membership in two prominent local food organizations or through participation at a farmers' market? To investigate direct interactions, we searched the farmers' and value-added participants' websites for information about whom they sell their products to and the websites of value-added producers, restaurant owners and retailers for whom they source their products from. In addition, we included references of direct interactions from interviews, e.g. when a seller mentioned they carry the product of a specific producer or worked with a specific producer during a promotional event. We examined indirect interactions through an online search of membership in the two

prominent organizations or participation in their events featuring local food. We selected the two organizations due to their prominence in the local food landscape; both are membership organizations for CSAs, one also provides snacks made with local food to schools, and both sponsor events that promote local food, including a bikeride to scenic farms, fundraising dinners, and local food festivals. Another indirect measure was whether the participants were vendors at a farmers' market in Madison, Wisconsin. We also used the interviews to examine whether the participants knew of each other without necessarily working together.

To examine whether the participant exhibited the three criteria that define a consumption community, we employed semi-structured in-depth interviews. Since our study was exploratory, we needed the participants to be able to express their beliefs, values, and attitudes in their own voice. While having a semi-structured interview guide allowed for some consistency, the minimal structuring of our interviews allowed us to pursue issues that were important to different participants, as well as explore the salience of local food concepts. This permitted following up on topics important to participants, probing unclear answers, but also comparison of answers across participants in our analysis (Legard et al., 2003).

Interviews were conducted between October 2013 and July 2014 with one interview conducted in February 2015. All participants were briefed on the purpose of the interview and asked to sign a human subjects internal review board (IRB) reviewed consent form; local food was not emphasized as a topic so as to not introduce bias. At the end of the interview, the participants were asked to fill out a short demographic questionnaire (Table 2).

Our questions focused on products, sourcing, and distribution to gauge participants' understanding of and interaction with local food and other producers. We were interested in finding whether the concept of local food was salient among the producers and whether and how

it delineated the characteristics of a consumption community. All producers raised the idea of local food by themselves, most of them in the first question that broadly asked them to define their business. The answers invariably brought up issues that warranted clarifying or follow-up questions. Important questions that emerged in the first couple of interviews were included in the interview guide for the following participants to allow for comparison.

The lead author conducted all interviews, audio-recorded them, transcribed them, checked them for accuracy and conducted thematic analysis. This approach is one of the most commonly used approaches in qualitative research because it allows to explore the data for themes rather than simply count frequency of words or phrases. Through theme coding, different aspects of the transcripts can be compared and contrasted to one another (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Saldana (2009) offers a rich description of coding procedures; ultimately suggesting that researchers will adopt styles that suit them best. The lead author initially coded for themes relevant to local foods in the manuscript, including perceptions, attitudes, and values associated with local foods and views of other local food producers and sellers. What emerged was an interesting contrast between those who were viewed as legitimate producers and sellers of local food and those who were not viewed as such. This contrast then provided the authors with the idea to employ a consumption community framework for coding.

The transcripts were then examined for the presence and absence of the three consumption community criteria. Specifically, the lead author coded for expressions of collective consciousness which included characteristics of those who belonged to the group as well as those who did not, narratives of use of local food, and shared moral obligation towards community and each other. The results, supplemented by quotes from participants, are described below.

Results

The online searches and interviews were used to establish whether there were direct and indirect interactions among the producers and sellers of local food in Madison, Wisconsin who participated in this study. The interactions between participants were assessed in two categories: (1) direct interactions based on remarks about interactions in interviews or a connection through selling products to one another from the producers' and sellers' websites and (2) indirect interactions, which included participating or being a member of a local food organization, selling products at a farmers' market, or remarks expressing knowledge of a given business without mentioning collaborations. While we understand that this view is limited and many more direct and indirect interactions are possible, such as knowing each other outside of local food or working together on other events, those interactions are more difficult to measure due to lack of information. The strength of interactions between participants could be addressed by future research.

Our results show that in general, the participants know of each other, interact with each other, and belong to common local food organizations in Madison, Wisconsin (Table 4). Overall, the farmers in this study appear to have fewer connections than the other participants, a part of this issue could be that Lis (FA 3) no longer had a website and Ryan (FA 1) and Ben (FA 2) exclusively used their websites to promote their CSA, thus they provided no web data to demonstrate relationships with others. We identified indirect interactions among the farmers through their participation at farmers' markets and membership in the two local food organizations. In addition, Ryan (FA 1) sold his food to Jonathan (RT 1), which was confirmed both in Ryan's (FA 1) transcript and on Jonathan's (RT 1) website.

Value-added producers did not identify the sources of their ingredients on their websites, but they appeared to be well connected to restaurants and retailers. The exception was Elliot (VA 3) who was not featured in any of the restaurants; this could be due to the nature of his product, which is difficult to use in cooking. Two value-added producers participated at a farmers' market; Leah (VA 1) could not participate given that her products are alcoholic beverages, which are prohibited from sale at the farmers' market. However, her product is featured in a number of the restaurants near the Capitol Square, where the farmers' market is held every week.

All the restaurants and retailers with the exceptions of Michael (RT 3) and Nathan (RO 3) were connected to the two local food organizations. However, only two participants, Michael (RT 3) and Jonathan (RE 1), published a full list of local food suppliers; the other participants published an incomplete list or none at all. This lack of published information is surprising for two reasons. First, the participants often called for transparency in local food supply chains, so not publishing their sources of food directly contradicts this message. Second, this could point to the decreasing importance of identifying specific farmers in advertising and the ascendance of "local food" as sufficient to attract customers.

Even if not all participants interacted with each other nor mentioned them in interviews, the data shows interconnectedness of local businesses in Madison, Wisconsin. This interconnectedness can facilitate propagation of community values and growth of a community but it does not necessarily signal the existence of one. Therefore, to investigate whether this is a production community, we turn to the interviews to examine the three criteria for consumption community: collective consciousness, rituals and traditions, and moral obligation. Before examining each of these, we would like to note the participants' prominent use of the "us vs. them" concept to distinguish between the members of the local food community and others. To

easily distinguish between the two groups, we borrow the group psychology terms “in-group” and “out-group” to define those who do and those who do not belong to the group, respectively, in our description of the three characteristics below.

Collective consciousness: Setting up group values and opposition to others

Our analysis showed that nearly all participants exhibited collective consciousness by outlining differences between in-group and out-group members. Through coding, two categories of attributes emerged: (1) business and product features and (2) values, passion and hard work of the owner. We found the “us vs. them” mentality expressed by participants to be so ingrained in their rhetoric that they repeatedly portrayed themselves congruently with the in-group characteristics throughout the interviews. The participants used this narrative to establish their in-group membership and distinguish themselves from the out-group. The exceptions were Nathan (RE 3) and Michael (RT 3) who expressed different sentiments throughout their interviews that will be discussed later. In addition, Lis (FA 3) did not appear to share the same rhetoric; possible explanations include cultural differences due to his ethnicity and his lack of interactions with other producers’, restaurants’, and retailers’ given his membership in a farmer cooperative that distributes his product.

All 12 participants discussed business and product features, outlining the differences between themselves and others; the rhetoric was not as strong for Lis (FA 3), Nathan (RE 3) and Michael (RT 3) who only pointed out the quality of the products they offered. The other participants characterized themselves and the in-group members as owners of small businesses who worked to connect customers with farmers and produced high quality product. The out-

group members were described as large businesses that effectively prevented their customers from reaching the farmer and their products were viewed as compromised. Leah (VA1) provided an example of these differences:

“[The breweries] are often held by public conglomerates, sometimes not even in the United States and ...the craft, the culture of their beer isn’t the same as ours. We’re all about ingredients, and we’re pure, we use water, hops, malt and yeast, the larger guys will use adjuncts and findings in their beer like fish guts, corn, gluten, [inaudible], whatever they get their hands on.”

While in general the participants positioned themselves against national companies, franchises, and conglomerates, some of them also excluded local companies. For instance, Jonathan (RE 1) and Nick (RE 2) both discussed other local restaurants that featured numerous local food products to be in the out-group because they ordered through one large distributor, while Jonathan (RE 1) and Nick (RE 2) both sourced from individual farmers. This implies that the in-group boundaries were not only based on size of the business and quality of the product, but also sourcing method for local food. Note that the participants’ businesses vary in size, where they source from, what their product is and where they distribute (Table 5), yet with the exception of Michael (RT 3) and Nathan (RE 3) their rhetoric places them to the in-group. This means that the boundaries of the in-group are flexible and not necessarily based on simple rules.

In addition to business and product characteristics, our analysis revealed that eight of the participants also distinguished themselves from others based on values that guided their motivation to participate in local food. This discourse is dominated by the conversation of

“right” and “wrong” values. While having the “wrong” values may signal an illegitimate member of the group even if they are producing and selling local foods, having the “right” values might legitimize decisions not to source locally. The former sentiment is illustrated by a quote from Will (RT 1):

“I don’t begrudge them that they are trying to sell product and that’s where the money is right now, but we’re also doing it because that’s what we believe in and we’ve always believed in it.”

To the participants, not having the “right” values implied co-opting local food for profit, which was viewed as unsavory. In fact, six participants further legitimized this position by discussing their “thin” profit margins and how they were not participating in local food to make money. This rhetoric stands in contrast to the participants’ income (Table 2) and business growth; in past years these businesses have been successful enough that they opened additional venues, increased production, and widened their distribution radii.

Nathan (RE 3) and Michael (RT 3) positioned themselves against this rhetoric by discussing the contradiction between values and profit, which hinted at elitism of the in-group. Nathan (RE 3) described how the lack of affordability of local food at venues such as RE 1 could hurt local food movement and result in some consumers refusing to purchase local foods altogether. Michael (RT 3) suggested that Will (RT 1) was using local foods to “emotionally pull on [customer’s] wallet;” in this way Will (RT 1) was able to appeal to consumers’ values to gain more profit. Nathan (RE 3) implied that this could harm local food in the long run:

“The experience that somebody has when they are drinking [other local coffee roaster] and they drink ours, the level of improvement for not that much more money is a lot more valuable to the local sustainable thing than the little increment you might get, and I say might, from drinking ours to drinking something that is \$30 to \$40/pound. So I think like what’s the point of saying local and doing all this stuff if no one can afford it.”

While having the “wrong” values was used to exclude some from the community, some participants implied that having the “right” values could justify compromising the product. In

some cases, sourcing ingredients locally was difficult or not possible, but having in-group values qualified one for exemptions, e.g. using lemons or truffles. This poses an interesting challenge to the idea of product loyalty since members did not have to be loyal to the product itself, but rather to the idea of thinking about the product congruently with in-group values. This concept is illustrated by a quote from Jonathan (RE 1):

“If you look at somebody like [name] from [another local brewery] in Madison, he’s a super small scale CSA brewer. There’s something really, really cool about that. Are all of the products that he’s using to make that local? No, but I bet that he’s spending a fair amount of time thinking about how it can be.”

The last feature of the in-group identified by four participants was passion and hard work.

The participants valued passion and hard work in others and described themselves as such to legitimize their own position in the in-group. The participants described farmers who spent all day in the dirt or the small business owners who managed all parts of the production process by themselves while competing with others. These participants viewed other practices, for instance ordering food from a distributor, as too easy. Samantha (RT 2) exemplified this by describing a value added producer she admired:

“In the last 12 months she opened her own business and she’s in Chicago which is 150 miles from us and it’s a new business start-up. She drives to four different states every month to drop off her handmade pies and she’s starting to roll out brownies ... I mean that’s a full service business, she’s doing it all on her own. ... So she’s struggling, trying to figure out how to talk about her business, she has to do the marketing on top of everything else.”

Such descriptions promoted the protestant ethic of hard work by describing the participants as hard working people, which made them inherently good. This brought up two issues: first, there was a lack of acknowledgment of the invisible workers, often undocumented immigrants, in both local and conventional food chains who work hard and struggle to earn money. In addition, in this quote the seller glorified an inefficient and unsustainable process of personal delivery across four states that was rationalized by the hard work of the producer. This

implies that the producers and sellers can be included in the local food community if they have the “right” values and are perceived as working hard, even when they are not sustainable, which affects the actual sustainability of local food.

Throughout their interviews the participants used collective consciousness to describe attributes of the in-group and position themselves against out-group members; the criterion of collective consciousness is therefore satisfied. The participants used features of products, businesses and owners to assess whether one belongs to the in-group or not; in addition, they used this rhetoric to legitimize their own place in this community. Collective consciousness in this community is largely used to exclude some participants from this group while at the same time legitimize the presence of other participants who may be producing in unsustainable ways. However, our results demonstrate a chicken-and-egg problem: do the characteristics determine group membership or does group membership create the perception of these characteristics? Some of the quotes we presented would suggest the latter, however further research is needed to confirm this.

Rituals and traditions: Signaling collective consciousness and advertising

Our analysis showed that for this group of producers and sellers, rituals and traditions around local food interactions consisted of narratives of product sourcing and creation. The farmers’ narratives revolved around growing their vegetables using the “correct” practices, highlighting the environment and healthfulness and freshness of their products. However, because they do not source their products, we exclude them from the rest of this section on rituals and traditions. The rest of the participants with the exception of Nathan (RE 3) and Michael (RT 3), who said they source products according to demand, described their process of

sourcing as often learning how to source local food, the decisions they had to make, and the journeys they took to find out about the people and the processes involved in food production.

The participants' narratives revolved around direct contact, either in person or on the phone, with those they were sourcing from, including local farmers, distributors, or retailers. The "handshake with the farmer" to them represented trust, guaranteed sustainable practices, and high quality products. The participants contrasted this style of sourcing with sourcing through national processors and distributors, which they considered inferior.

"We chose to not go through say one of those, the absolute world's largest flour companies, which is pervasive in all of the large broadline distribution houses, and we decided to go straight to the mill in North Dakota at which point I even talked with the mill and asked them like 'What silos are you pulling from?' I found a two thousand-mile square area in far northwest corner of North Dakota and was able to even call like local associations there to talk to the farmers, which I don't think that would ever be possible if I've ever gone through ConAgra." Elliot (VA 3)

This quote demonstrated the effort put into teasing out who produced the sourced products. This quest to "talk" with the person who produced it guaranteed trust because they believed people did not lie face to face. In addition, often they traveled to different locations to confirm the practices. However, their decision-making had to balance sustainability with affordability and size:

"If I'm looking for organic mixed greens, you know, let's say there's three people who can provide that, that are within our 50 miles radius let's say, and then there's all sorts of factors about how we would decide for one of those three, I mean choose one of those three. One, do we know the people? Do we know that they are using sustainable practices? Are they certified organic? Or are they just saying that they are doing it organically? Have we visited the place? Have we seen the farm itself? How often do they deliver? Are they easy to work with? So a whole bunch of different factors and then of course, what the price is for what they're selling." Nick (RE 2)

Seven participants viewed price as directly compromising sustainability; the more sustainable the product was, the more expensive it would have to be. Similarly, six participants found challenges in size; the smallest producers have the most sustainable practices or are the most local, but they could not provide enough products to satisfy demand. For this reason, compromises had to be made, as described by Will (RT 1):

“So it’s a good, one of our, it’s in our mission statement to run an economically sound business, so it, we do have all of the ideals but they’re kind of grounded in if we don’t make money, we don’t exist. We can’t be around to help local farmers and organic farmers and get food to our owners and get back to the community so we have to make some money. We don’t want to make too much, we want to make just enough.”

This stood in direct contrast with the values they defined for the in-group. The participants claimed to be involved because of their values and not for profit, so why did they not support the most sustainable practices? Three of the participants explained that if they did not make enough money, they would not be able to sell local and organic food to customers or support local producers in the future.

Our analysis reveals that the participants shared narratives about product sourcing and creation, which some of the participants viewed as directly contrasting the practices of other businesses who they viewed as not being able to describe what was in their food. These narratives followed collective consciousness, effectively outlining the desired characteristics of the in-group members. This implies that these narratives have an important role in how the community members understand each other and how they portray themselves to others. Specifically, the participants highlighted the quality of their products and demonstrated how they worked hard to make the best decisions. To others, the stories could express in-group values, which could be replicated to guarantee group entry. At the same time, the participants showed an inconsistency in their values; money and business size played a major role in their decision-

making. This directly contradicted their attempts to portray the in-group as people who do things for the right reasons instead of thinking about money or having enough products to offer.

In addition, these narratives could be used for advertising. The narratives featured farmers and producers in their stores or in their restaurants, telling the stories of how products were produced, thus propagating the values of the group to others. Nathan (RE 3) and Michael (RT 3) criticized this approach and were cynical about sharing stories of the hard-working farmer. Michael (RT 3) suggested that this kind of advertising makes food appear local regardless of where it was from; specifically, he said that if a farmer's picture is next to a product, it becomes local. Nathan (RE 3) took this sentiment even further, arguing that the desire for such stories together with lack of affordability might turn people away from local products, implying that the romanticism surrounding local food may in fact be elitist:

“[People say] ‘well if I’m not drinking one that is second brother’s cousin that has gold plated llamas harvesting their coffee’ or something like that, I mean, it’s just that it will scare people away from actually trying some things that are very different from mass produced [coffee].”

This quote highlights how such narratives can create an aura of exclusivity, which effectively limits the reach of local food.

Moral obligation: The right thing for the community

Our analysis revealed that moral obligation was a strong theme in the rhetoric of all but one participant; the moral obligation consisted of helping the community and local economy through helping other in-group local food producers and sellers. In this section, we use the term “local community” to include those who the participants viewed as the greater community; we use the term “production community” to describe the producers and sellers of local food. Unlike

other participants, Nathan (RE 3), Samantha (RT 2) and Michael (RT 3) discuss actual involvement in their neighborhood or support for local charities. Lis (FA 3) on the other hand said he felt obligation to provide people with healthy food and support youth in his community who wanted to start farming.

In general, participants referred to supporting the local community without any qualifiers of who this community was or how they were supporting them. Based on our coding, the majority of moral obligation was based on the economy; the participants said that they were interested in creating jobs, having money flow back into the community and they wanted to support local farmers and producers. This was exemplified by the following quote from Elliot (VA 3):

“[Goal number] two is to continually interact and be amongst the other food companies and producers here and support them in any way we can. Also support our farmers and try to have more initiative and projects that we can start bringing in and using ingredients and also our work force and things like that.”

The participants brought up support for other producers who, based on the described characteristics, could belong to the in-group, specifically, because they were hard-working, were producing a product of high quality and in general, had the same set of values. Nine participants indicated specific support for farmers, who were viewed as the basis of local food but in this study they were in the lowest income quintile, much lower than the other producers and sellers.

Overall, moral obligation was felt primarily towards other producers and sellers, which implies a divergence from market competition. The values expressed as collective consciousness were used to justify supporting others. The participants supported each other by promoting and featuring each other's products, which can be viewed as a gesture of good will. However, the producers and sellers viewed local food as being in demand, so getting their products to more producers and sellers as well as aligning themselves with organizations promoting local food is a

form of advertising. Whether the moral obligation extends beyond market transactions is therefore a question to be addressed in future research.

Discussion

Our case study provides evidence for the existence of a community among the producers and sellers of local food in Madison, Wisconsin. The participants' rhetoric exhibited the three determinants of a consumption community: collective consciousness, rituals and traditions, and moral obligation. Given that consumption communities often focus on the consumer, we coin the term "production community" to emphasize the corresponding relationships among producers. The three determinants of a community outlined group values and culture, which facilitated distinguishing between the in-group and out-group, included the participants' view on local food and sustainability, and determined the need to help other in-group members and their local community.

Outlining group boundaries and positioning group against others is an important mechanism of collective consciousness (Gusfield, 1978). In this case study, the "us vs. them" mentality emerged in participants' descriptions of themselves, the narratives of their sourcing decisions, and their support for others. The participants viewed themselves as standing against large corporations that compromised product quality, which has also been found among CSA farmers and members (Thompson & Coskuner-Balli, 2014). Standing against the giants could be beneficial to local food sales; Paharia et al. (2014) found invoking a large competitor increased sales of smaller companies.

However, national conglomerates were not the only ones in the out-group. The participants demonstrated that simply being small and involved in local food production and

selling were not the only desired in-group characteristics. Instead, some local companies and farmers could be excluded based on other criteria, such as perceived values and practices. The participants represented their values as normative reality; they viewed themselves as acting in the “right” way. However, whether and how they assessed the values and practices of other businesses remains a question, especially given that the businesses of the participants themselves varied in size, products offered, sourcing, and distribution.

Acting the “right” way included not being interested in profit; this stood in direct opposition to the non-farmer participants’ high incomes and growing businesses. The participants considered their values to be the “right” guiding principles, those who were viewed as being interested in profit were considered to be co-opting local food, a strategy for which national chains have been condemned (Mitchell, 2009). This presents an interesting dilemma for local food supporters: would increasing sales of local food, and hence revenues to farmers, be considered “wrong” if one is perceived as co-opting local food?

Another important aspect of the participants’ narratives was hard work, which was implicitly equated with goodness. Hard working people are good people, even if they compromise sustainability. Aside from propagating in-group values, the narratives of hard work can appeal to the consumer, potentially producing moral obligation (Carson et al., 2016; Schnell, 2013). These narratives are echoed in local food literature. For instance, the narrative of American pastoralism and romanticism has been used to promote CSA (Press & Arnould, 2013; Thompson & Coskuner-Balli, 2007). However, these narratives can also be co-opted to promote the products of companies the participants’ opposed, for instance, Lays featured hard working local potato farmers in their “The Lays Local” campaign (Lohan, 2009).

This portrayal of hard work of by owner/operators can be harmful to the goals of the local food movement in general because it does not recognize the hard work of local and organic farm workers (Shreck et al., 2006) or the hard work of farm workers in conventional food systems (Alkon, 2013). Nor does it recognize the hardships of immigrant workers in American food service in general (Zepeda, 2015). This narrative of local food can turn our attention away from issues in American agriculture and food service, instead of working towards solutions for social sustainability and social justice.

Overall, while the participants expressed some criteria for admission to the community, the question remains whether other, unspoken criteria were present. The demographics of this group hint at privilege: overall, the group membership was White, male, with a college degree, and high-income, and their products were generally more expensive (Table 2). This does not leave much space for others who do not have the same economic, social and cultural capital. In fact, their lack of recognition of others who work hard and invest emotionally into what they are making, as well as their assumption that everyone can afford to be uninterested in profit, provides some evidence of who they do not see as a part of their community: the poor, immigrants, women, and minorities.

While the participants described complicated strategies and weighed different aspects of sustainability, two possible issues for sustainability based on in-group values emerged. First, the participants based their knowledge on a “handshake with the farmer;” the direct contact created trust. Is trust a guarantee of actual sustainable practices? Some of the participants indicated actually visiting farms; however, we do not know what specific criteria they used and how they evaluated them.

Second, aside from sustainability, the participants' also considered similar values of the business owner, pricing, and consistency of supply, which was a proxy for the size of a business, in their decision making. The participants sometimes chose to source from people who lived further away because they appreciated someone with similar values or chose a cheaper product from a larger producer to be able to offer a consistent supply of affordable products. While these practices should in no way be considered unethical or "wrong," this implies that these producers and sellers may not always be making the most sustainable choices. It could also mean that some small, more sustainable and therefore more expensive producers could have a harder time finding a market for their products. Consumers interested in promoting sustainability should not therefore assume that these producers and sellers make the most sustainable decisions. Instead, consumers may want verification of sustainability or demand information about sourcing and production.

The potential major benefit of belonging to a production community identified in this study was the participants' feeling of obligation to the other local food producers and sellers. They considered this to directly help their community by keeping money in the community and providing jobs. To them this meant that supporting others was the "right" thing to do. However, who is this local community the participants are interested in helping? Given the prices for the products and the location of the businesses in mostly more White, affluent neighborhoods, the local community seems to include people similar to the producers. In addition, the participants overlooked the jobs and the money brought into the community by larger producers and sellers. Could this group of small local producers offset the jobs lost by the recent closure of a Kraft factory in Madison? Supporting one's community is an important value; however, reflexive

thinking about who this community is and who does not belong in it needs to be a part of this discourse if local foods are to reach more people.

The obligation to help other producers and sellers is consistent with psychological literature on in-group affinity and out-group discrimination that concludes that group members preferentially distribute resources to other in-group members (Everett et al., 2015). This could benefit (or harm) beginning farmers and those who want to start their own local food business. The participants expressed beliefs that helping each other was necessary because those who work with local food work hard and deserve to be supported. Moral obligation could therefore facilitate shifting away from market competition towards collaborations and recruitment of new producers and sellers. However, it may also imply that those who are not deemed to be part of the in-group may not receive help from this community and as a result, their businesses may be unsuccessful.

An important point to make is that supporting each other does not come without economic benefits. The support reported by the participants revolved around market transactions: they supported others by purchasing and promoting each other's products, or through sponsorships of fundraisers of local food organizations that promote local food. The support for non-profit organizations and small producers could result in increased pro-social marketing, which could attract more customers who are looking to consume politically and for the "right" reasons. These not-for-profit organizations, while encouraging support of local food, also create an elite group of local food producers who they feature at events, especially for fundraising. This particularly applies to the case of farm-to-table restaurant chefs who are treated like stars of the local food movement. Tickets at a recent fundraising dinner featuring these chefs went for \$150 per person, effectively excluding all but affluent consumers.

This case study of a production community among local food producers and sellers in Madison, Wisconsin has implications for future research in consumer studies, as well as for local food activists and advocates. If production communities are similar to consumption communities, are there parallels between their benefits? For instance, does identification with the community strengthen brand loyalty? Do members recruit others and help them with production? While we reported a number of potential positive aspects, including helping other members, two issues emerged in this production community that could challenge participation in this community and compromise support for sustainability. First, the participants excluded a number of people from their narratives and from the group, e.g. smaller businesses that do not necessarily comply with their local food guidelines and agricultural/food workers. The group appeared to be exclusive, which could limit participation and involvement. Second, the participants used their values to justify making less sustainable decisions. If this is a part of the group norms, this community could be compromising sustainability while claiming to be promoting it. These two issues need to be addressed if local food production is to become more widespread, supporting more producers, sellers and consumers.

This case study is limited by its scope and methods. While this study is limited to the views of 12 participants in Madison, Wisconsin, it is important to note that they interact with many others in the local food community through the same channels. This implies that the in-group we describe could be much larger because it could include others who have similar interactions. At the same time, the out-group in this study only included two participants, who also appeared to be oriented toward the local community. The conclusions about the views of the out-group are limited to the views of only two particular members; future research should

address the relationships between the in-group and the out-group and its consequences for sustainability and local food culture.

Other limitations are connected to the methods of this study. The study consisted of an online search, which highlights connections between the participants, but it did not speak to the quality of the connections. While some of the connections were mentioned in the interviews, they were not explored in depth; rather, they were used as examples of connections in Madison, Wisconsin. It would be interesting to see whether and how the aspect of moral obligation would change if the participants discussed actual connections with other participants. The study also included interviews, which while informative, could be skewed by social desirability bias. However, the characteristics of the interviewer were similar to those of the participants, which should allow the participants to speak more freely about their personal opinions.

While this case study outlined the connections between participants, as well as possible exclusion criteria, we are interested in understanding how these processes happen. We have suggested that the rhetoric of participants delineates the in-group and out-group, but we have not addressed the processes of recruiting new members. This could highlight how inclusion and exclusion work in this community and elucidate how to make the community more inclusive.

Regardless of the scope of this study, we believe the concept of a production community is useful to examine local food. We found that the participants in this study interacted with each other and while interactions alone do not guarantee the existence of a community, shared experiences can strengthen it (McAlexander et al., 2002). This implies that our results could be applicable to other cities with a vibrant local food culture. Carlson et al. (2008) suggest that psychological consumption communities can be founded merely on perceptions of similarity, it is therefore possible that a larger, geographically dispersed local food production community

exists. A future study could include case studies of other locations in the U.S. to demonstrate whether production communities exist in different places, their similarities and differences, and the consequences for the local food movement regarding inclusion and sustainability.

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Article 3: Can Self-Determination Theory Explain the Self-Perpetuation of Social Innovations? A Case Study of Slow Food at the University of Wisconsin—Madison

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Abstract

This case study of Slow Food at the University of Wisconsin—Madison (SFUW) examines the success of a volunteer social innovation that promotes sustainable food access. Using inductive thematic analysis of 19 in-depth, semi-structured interviews of past and current members, advisors, and collaborators, we find that the success of SFUW is consistent with Self-Determination Theory. We find that among the participants, the organization satisfies the basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness, which in turn support intrinsic motivation. In this way, volunteering tasks become interesting, fun, and are more likely to be performed over time. The findings suggest that needs fulfillment and intrinsic motivation are linked to creating a self-propagating social innovation where volunteers generate new ideas and successfully transfer skills to others.

Introduction

Taylor (1970) coined the phrase social innovation to characterize new practices addressing social needs resulting from market or government failures. The process of social innovation remains understudied (Mulgan, 2006) despite its documented impact on economic and social well-being (Howaldt & Schwartz, 2010; Moulaert et al., 2005; Phills et al., 2008). Within the food systems, social innovations have arisen to address problems of food access and

sustainability; examples include Community Supported Agriculture (CSA) and mobile markets (Russell & Zepeda, 2008; Zepeda et al., 2014).

Mulgan (2006) describes the success of a social innovation as the transition from an idea to a movement, which suggests that momentum and self-perpetuation are essential. Therefore, a volunteer organization must be economically viable and able to attract a continual stream of volunteers. In order to examine what factors contribute to the success and self-perpetuation of a volunteer social innovation, we present a case study of Slow Food University of Wisconsin—Madison (SFUW), which prepares and offers the community about 500 locally sourced affordable meals per week. Through inductive thematic analysis of 19 interviews with key players in the organization since its inception in 2007, we examine the SFUW, finding that Self-Determination Theory (SDT) (Deci & Ryan, 2000) explains volunteer motivation and organization success. SDT posits that intrinsic motivation needed for repeated behaviors and personal well-being is strongest when basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness are satisfied. SDT has been used previously to describe motivation in the work place, organizational citizenship, and volunteering (Baard et al., 2005; Deci et al., 2001; Gagné & Deci, 2005; Haivas et al., 2012). However, these assessments were limited to the concepts of autonomy support and autonomy orientation. Our approach is novel in that we specifically examine whether and how one's basic psychological needs are satisfied by participating in SFUW and whether the participants exhibit intrinsic motivation to volunteer and contribute their ideas.

Literature Review

Social innovation and volunteering

Social innovations often have prominent social goals that become intentional practice, resulting in social change and commercial success (Howaldt & Schwarz, 2010). Phills et al. (2008) stress that social innovations must be novel, more sustainable and/or more just than the current practice, and benefit society as a whole. Social innovations can change social relations to increase participation, empowerment, wellbeing, and access to resources of underrepresented groups (Moulaert et al., 2005).

In their book, Murray et al. (2010) discuss examples of how social innovations emerge and the methods that spread and perpetuate their use. However, they do not examine the identity of the participants nor their motivations to join and stay with an organization. This is especially important for volunteer-based social innovations, where monetary rewards may be nonexistent.

A review of volunteering literature reveals that the ‘who’ and ‘why’ of volunteering are difficult to establish. One of the challenges is that volunteering lacks a generally accepted definition and can involve different activities (Hustinx et al., 2010). In their review, Bussell and Forbes (2002) identify demographics as key explanatory variables. Volunteer motivation is often subject to functional analysis, as exemplified by Clary and Snyder’s (1999) Volunteer Functions Inventory (VFI). The VFI consists of six personal and social functions: supporting one’s values, exercising new skills, feeling good about oneself, gaining career advancement, creating new relationships, and forgetting one’s problems. Applications show that different people have different, and often more than one reasons to volunteer (Clary & Snyder, 1999; Papadakis et al., 2004). The VFI is criticized for being limited; in an open-probe study, other motivations such as enjoyment, religiousness, and team-building emerged (Allison et al., 2002). Agostinho and Paco

(2012) further demonstrate that the specific function is related to involvement: volunteers with altruistic and social motivations contribute more time.

Functional analysis is the tool of choice in understanding participation in food systems innovations. Researchers study local food purchases at farmers' markets or CSAs (Brown, 2003; Hinrichs & Kremer, 2002) using surveys containing functional items such as 'food freshness' or 'supporting local farmers' to explain purchase of goods or services. The literature on food system innovations is limited to purchase; literature on contribution of one's time or ideas is lacking.

Our approach is novel in that it goes beyond functional motivations. We propose examining SDT as a unifying framework to understand volunteer recruitment and retention; rather than satisfying one or more functional motivations, volunteering must satisfy participants' basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Satisfaction of the three needs in turn leads to sustained motivation to invest one's time, energy, and ideas into the social innovation.

Self-determination theory and volunteering

SDT implies that the quality of one's motivation predicts one's effort and satisfaction towards a behavior. Specifically, one is more likely to be engaged in a behavior long-term and have fun performing it when their motivation is intrinsic (the behaviors are freely chosen and perceived as fun), rather than extrinsic (performed for a functional reason) (Deci & Ryan, 2000). Extrinsic motivation is subdivided into four types depending on regulation: integrated, identified, introjected, and external. Integrated regulation is the most autonomous type of extrinsic motivation with behaviors being fully integrated in one's perception of self. Identified regulation

means that one understands and values the behavior's importance. Introjected regulation is a form of internal pressure such as guilt. External regulation requires an external pressure or reward.

Ryan and Deci (2000) propose that the transition from the most controlled to the most autonomous motivation is facilitated by satisfaction of basic psychological needs for autonomy (free choice), competence (mastery), and relatedness (belonging). The needs are considered essential nutrients for one's well-being (Ryan et al., 1996). A behavior supporting the three needs might eventually be performed for its own sake, and therefore be performed with greater effort over time (Ryan & Deci, 2000).

SDT has been used to examine volunteer motivation (Haivas et al., 2012) and to investigate whether positive work outcomes are related to autonomous motivation both in the work place and in organizational citizenship (Baard et al., 2005; Deci et al., 2001; Gagné, 2003; Gagné & Deci, 2005; Ilardi et al., 1993; Kasser, Davey, & Ryan, 1992). Autonomy is often the focus of these studies. Managerial encouragement of decision-making and creativity leads to autonomous motivation and greater job satisfaction (Deci et al., 1994). Courtney (1994) argues that horizontal hierarchies in volunteer organizations allow for greater autonomy, which makes them more successful. Volunteering can foster autonomy by supporting one's sense of self (Omoto & Snyder, 1993). Deci (1971) has shown that verbal appreciation increases autonomous motivation and leads to more positive work outcomes, while external rewards lower autonomous motivation. This is crucial for volunteer organization because they rely on motivating volunteers through the organizational mission and volunteer experiences.

In contrast, relatedness and competence have received relatively little attention, perhaps because autonomy is easier for leadership to implement. Relatedness is considered supplemental

to autonomy and competence (e.g. Haivas et al., 2012) despite the fact that it can create an effective working environment (Hobson et al., 1996).

Within food systems' innovations, SDT has provided an explanation for member retention in CSA (Zepeda et al., 2013). While the results showed that needs satisfaction is linked to membership renewal, i.e. linked to willingness to pay for social innovation's services, it did not address volunteering one's time and ideas, which are fundamental to the success of volunteer-based social innovations.

This case study addresses the gaps in literature in that it investigates whether SDT can explain the self-perpetuation of a volunteer-based social innovation via the concept of the three basic psychological needs. Specifically, we focus on the following research questions:

- (1) Does SFUW support the three basic psychological needs for:
 - (a) autonomy;
 - (b) competence; and
 - (c) (c) relatedness?
- (2) Are members' continued participation and contribution of ideas intrinsically motivated?

The results provide insights about how to structure and manage volunteer-based social innovations to operate successfully, manage transition, and expand programs.

Case study: SFUW

SFUW is a student chapter of Slow Food International (SFI), founded by Carlo Petrini in 1989 in Bra, Italy in reaction to the spreading fast food culture. Initially promoting enjoyment of traditional, regional foods, SFI expanded its mission to include sustainability and social justice,

expressed as, ‘Good, Clean and Fair Food’ (Petrini, 2007). SFI has over 100000 members in 1300 local chapters in 153 countries supporting more than 5000 initiatives a year (SFI, n.d.) However, some critics view Slow Food as elitist because of its initial focus on food quality and refinement (Tam, 2008).

The SFUW chapter was founded by a graduate student, Genya Erling, in 2007 in response to SFI’s call for more student chapters and her concern about the price of meals at the Slow Food city chapter. SFUW grew from a dozen students making food together to a large, all-volunteer group providing over 500 meals per week to the community. Currently, SFUW includes a team of 13 leaders and 28 interns who sign-up to volunteer between 10 and 20h/week for a semester or a year as well as about 50 volunteers who help on drop-in basis. The organization obtained 501c3 non-profit status and is licensed as a restaurant.

SFUW has four main projects: Family Dinner Night, South Madison, Outreach, and the Slow Food Café. Family Dinner Night is the original program; it serves weekly \$5 dinners to about 120 people. South Madison has evolved from a small initiative offering gardening and cooking experiences for free to low-income children in community centres in 2009 to five separate social justice projects focusing on providing free meals to low-income people. Outreach focuses on activities to foster community connections and cooking skills. The Slow Food Café opened in February 2011, offering affordable lunches to over 200 people per week.

The short history of SFUW has not been without problems. Logistical issues arose from University’s liability concerns, which resulted in relocation from campus to the Crossing Ministries in 2009. Another threat to the organization came from leadership conflicts in the same year; they were overcome by conscious decisions to adopt an inclusive and facilitating leadership style. The current structure of the organization consists of a collaborative team of directors for

each of the projects as well as directors for finance, communications, website, internal and external membership, and a grant writer. All of the leaders and interns are unpaid; however, some may receive credit from a faculty advisor. While the role of some faculty advisors is limited to providing credit, several core faculty members respond to student initiatives by developing curricula, supporting the organizational mission, or helping to network with local organizations.

SFUW's success as a social innovation could not happen without the dedication of its volunteers, interns, leadership, and advisors, all of whom volunteer their time, skills, ideas, and enthusiasm for the organization. While different students may have different functional motivations, we investigate whether organizational success can be linked to satisfaction of three basic psychological needs, which in turn support intrinsic motivation.

Methods

This case study is a part of a project to document the history of SFUW by a co-author who has been involved with SFUW since its inception as a faculty advisor. She conducted in-depth semi-structured interviews with past and current members of SFUW. Semi-structured interviews have several advantages; they allow participants to freely express what is important to them through narrating their experiences as well as allow for consistency across participants and provide an option to ask probing questions and follow up on themes.

The participants were selected using a snowball sampling starting from the founders, who then identified others involved in developing key projects and representing different leadership and internship positions. The participants were contacted via email with a short explanation of the study and asked if they were willing to participate. All 19 participants who were contacted

agreed to participate (Table 6). Pseudonyms are used for all participants. ‘Generation’ refers to whether the participant was in the original founding group or joined later.

The interviews were conducted between November 2012 and August 2013 with nine interviews conducted in person and the rest via telephone or Skype. Prior to starting the interview, the researcher informed the participants about the purpose of the study and explained that the interviews were confidential. The participants were asked to provide an oral or written consent to participate and be quoted anonymously, as required by the Institutional Review Board (IRB).

The interview guide included 10 questions about the participants’ initial involvement, experiences, motivation, extent of participation, most and least favorite experiences, accomplishments, vision for the future, and transferability of SFUW to other settings. The interviewer asked participants to clarify or expand on their answers. The participants could add anything that was important to them.

The interviews were recorded, transcribed by a professional transcription service, and reviewed by both co-authors. A co-author applied inductive thematic analysis to the data (Braun & Clarke, 2006); this approach is fitting because as opposed to theoretical thematic analysis, the interview questions were general rather than theory driven. After familiarizing herself with the data, the co-author then generated initial codes (Saldana, 2009). The codes were reviewed and combined into themes to explore what makes SFUW successful. The themes were compared and contrasted across the data set together with analytical memos written throughout the process to create a conceptual map of the data. While the initial approach was inductive, the conceptual map revealed the applicability of SDT. The names for themes were then altered to reflect the

concepts of SDT (e.g. ‘connection to others’ became ‘relatedness’). The major themes are reviewed below.

Results

Data analysis revealed that the common threads connecting the interviews were satisfaction of the three basic psychological needs from SDT: autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Across the data, four trends were identified. First, the three basic needs are experienced on all levels of the organizational hierarchy; i.e. they are prominent in all interviews. Second, the experience involves directionality that is understood by the participants. Specifically, the participants discuss how others create an atmosphere where their needs are fulfilled and how they in turn facilitate needs fulfillment for others. Third, the basic psychological needs appear to be satisfied by both short-term projects (e.g. developing a café menu) and long-term aspirations (e.g. being a good leader). The prevalence of these themes suggests that psychological needs fulfillment is a social norm in the organization.

The last theme, and perhaps the one of most interest for SDT researchers, is the qualitative connection between autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Autonomy facilitates competence because the participants choose a task that is challenging but within their abilities, which leads to an increased sense of competence. In turn, they feel most competent when they can share their success with others and feel appreciated, which is an expression of relatedness. Relatedness encourages trust, which allows the participants to provide greater autonomy to others. These connections appear to enhance each of the psychological needs, suggesting that satisfaction is greatest when the needs work in tandem. In the following sections we outline some

of the ways the psychological needs are exhibited in the interviews and how they connect to intrinsic motivation.

Autonomy: exploring, growing, and promoting

All participants describe how important it was to them that they were able to freely make decisions. For many students, this was their first experience with autonomy. Monica, an intern, illustrates the general feeling within SFUW:

“SFUW is kind of unique, where no one told us we could do whatever we wanted, but we kind of just did whatever we wanted. And so we were able to get any kind of experience that was needed and kind of make this model and make the best out of it.”

The participants not only understand and appreciate the autonomy they received, but they also articulate how essential it is to provide it to others. Chloe, who became an intern after volunteering, describes how she facilitated autonomy and intrinsic motivation for the weekly kitchen volunteers. Since she started in SFUW as a volunteer, she reflected on how this strategy can create a stable fleet of volunteers and therefore tries to instill it in others:

“I was going around and talking to people and making sure they were having a good time and also wanting to involve people in the creative development. It was making them feel like they had a part in what it was we were creating.”

The leadership team corroborated this; Marleen talked about how the directors provide autonomy to the interns:

“The best part about it was working with the interns, and my particular leadership style was, ‘you’ve got an idea? Great, let’s run with it.’ And really allowing students to kind of go where they wanted and to really take ownership of their internship. And my role was basically supportive, saying, ‘what do you need? How can I help you? Are there any conflicts we need to resolve? What resources do you need?’ ... I was very much about individual empowerment of the interns and giving them kind of the freedom, with enough structure, but giving them the freedom to really craft their own internship. And I think it was successful. People got really excited about their own internships.”

Autonomy is also fostered by the faculty advisors; Marilyn recounted her experience with Liza, a faculty who let SFUW interns design a for-credit course:

“I think the faculty who’ve worked with SF have been remarkable in giving us the space to grow. And that trust that we won’t—you know—Liza saying: ‘Yeah, I’ll let you guys teach a class and I’ll put my name to it and stand up to the university, if need be, about this.’ That’s powerful. That’s powerful for a student to hear that kind of affirmation from a faculty person and say—run with it. I believe you can do this. I feel that’s been a huge part of how SF[UW] has grown and expanded from the past.”

Autonomy is important on all levels of organizational hierarchy and it is achieved through both small, everyday tasks, and long-term projects; question 1a is therefore upheld. All the participants appreciated autonomy and understood that they need to provide it to others in order to have a successful organization.

Competence: everyday tasks and building projects

As a theme, competence was present in all interviews regardless of whether the participants talked about small tasks or long-term projects. The sense of mastery was especially apparent when participants recounted their favorite memories, as illustrated by Cecilia:

“I think for me, [the most important accomplishment] is the satisfaction of serving 200 people in 3 hours. Sometimes you get (a feeling of) accomplishment by people, by the food that you make.”

Cecilia and others made an important point of recognition and appreciation by others. This corresponds to an earlier formulation of SDT by Deci (1971) who posited that verbal appreciation increases intrinsic motivation. This suggests a connection between competence and relatedness as described by Marleen:

“To get that sort of appreciation back, it was heartening and rejuvenating as like, we’re in this together.”

Similarly to autonomy, the participants understood how competence makes the experience fulfilling and so they actively tried to recreate it for others. Chloe, a café intern, talked about the importance of instilling competence through ownership and appreciation among volunteers:

‘I felt that if somebody felt as if they had contributed to make the products, then they would want to come back, because they would feel that it was a rewarding experience. They could tell their friends at the table (I made that) and take ownership over that.’

As opposed to autonomy, competence is more difficult to foster. Sarah illustrates how dissatisfaction with one’s experience because of lack of competence can be disheartening by recalling a poorly attended event she planned:

“I think that my least favorite experience was all of those trial and errors that we made when we were trying to figure out the best kind of after-school kids’ program to have.”

In another example, Marleen, an SFUW leader, recognizes the importance of competence for generating positive experiences. Recalling a program she struggled with, she describes how she wanted the subsequent interns to have a different experience:

“The other thing has been struggling with the [...] project, it has been weighing on my mind a lot in that trying to find a niche for that project and trying to, because I want the experience to be good for the interns.”

Competence was an important part of the SFUW experience; therefore question 2b was upheld. Having both short-term experiences of competence as well as long-term, more complex experiences coupled with appreciation by others contributed to participants’ motivation to be a part of SFUW.

Relatedness: community within and ties to the world

Relatedness, the feeling of belonging, appears to be the unifying theme of the SFUW experience. The interviews demonstrate that SFUW created and recreated the feeling of

belonging to attract new members, to encourage them to become more involved, and to retain them. This feeling of belonging was not limited to SFUW members; it was also felt toward the community in general.

While the participants describe coming to SFUW for different reasons, be it student group involvement, interest in cooking, or simply following a friend, they all experienced the space and the community as welcoming. Lucy's experience of looking for a 'niche' in college and finding it in SFUW was typical:

"The transition my freshman year was really difficult, and I was having trouble finding people that I really fit in with and had the same interests as me. ... And it was, I don't know, something just about the people there. ... You sort of felt like you were part of like the big family."

The nature of the activities allowed the volunteers to immediately engage not only with the tasks themselves, but also with others, as Sarah and Marilyn respectively described:

"I remember going there and being invited to help cook right away."

"They give you a space to meet people in a way that's not intimidating. ... If I'm chopping (food) next to somebody, it's so much easier to engage them in conversation than if I'm sitting next to them on a bus."

The feeling of belonging to a community was often responsible for participant retention; the community was so warm that Chloe described it in very physical terms:

"I stayed because of just the feeling of almost being hugged by these people that I didn't know before."

As with autonomy and competence, the participants recognized how instrumental relatedness was for attracting volunteers as Sarah's vision for SFUW illustrates:

"I'd like to see Slow Food open the kitchen doors and sort of create this welcoming, open kitchen, open-house atmosphere that it had when I first stepped into the kitchen."

The participants indicated that the feeling of belonging is essential to attracting participation from those who attend SFUW events or meals, which is key to making SFUW successful. Marleen noted this regarding the Café:

“Every time you go down there, there’s something. There’s a pulse in that room, and that’s really exciting. So to provide that kind of energy and excitement about local food or about gathering space has been a really great aspect of the café as well.”

While autonomy and competence can function regardless of size, relatedness is threatened by ‘growing pains’. With growth, many participants recognized the difficulty of staying connected. This was particularly apparent in the interviews of the leadership team, who were concerned about the size of the team, while the interns often mentioned lack of connection between participants at events. Greta and Phoebe illustrated those two issues:

“I think that’s been the most challenging thing, has been trying to help ourselves grow sustainably but also like keep it, keep everyone well connected. That’s probably been the biggest challenge.”

“Even though the energy was really great on nights where it was over 100 people eating together I think that was actually my least favorite experience. It was seeing something that I’d gotten from something so intimate to something where I wasn’t really sure that the heart of Family Dinner Night was still there.”

Another aspect of belonging is creating connections to the community at large. For most participants, it was absolutely essential that they made connections beyond the boundaries of the university because it helped them realize that their cause was important. Greta described how heartwarming the connection was with the recipients of SFUW services:

“They’re not really customers to us. They’re like, everyone’s a family.”

All the interviews showed that relatedness was important for self-propagation of the organization; question1c was therefore upheld. By feeling and recreating belonging within the

organization as well as maintaining ties to the greater community, SFUW was able to attract new members and expand their activities and influence.

Do autonomy, competence, and relatedness create intrinsic motivation?

SDT states that when three psychological needs are satisfied, people are more likely to internalize motivation. The interviews reveal that SFUW created and recreated autonomy, competence, and relatedness for the participants, and indeed, all participants exhibited strong intrinsic motivation; for them, SFUW is interesting and fun. This is the reason they kept coming back to volunteer their time and ideas.

The participants often made links between the three psychological needs and intrinsic motivation. For different participants, different aspects of the basic psychological needs were the most motivating. For instance Peter explained how he was motivated by autonomy because of the horizontal organizational structure:

“[We had] the responsibility of being our own bosses, I think, was something that, at least for me, made it so motivating, is that we were working for one another ourselves and not for some higher up within a large organization or some professor or some whatever.”

For Sophie, intrinsic motivation was clearly connected to relatedness:

“And what you need to do is just get people together and get passions going and just start making friendships. And that’s the only way people are going to put that much time into it is if they’re enjoying it and feel like they’re part of the community, I think.”

The quotes throughout this section not only demonstrate the importance of social norms concerning autonomy, competence, and relatedness to organizational success, but they also show that the leaders and interns instinctively understand this. They think critically about their success and realize that these psychological needs create greater involvement, which in turn ensures SFUW self-propagation.

Discussion and Conclusions

Previous findings in studies of volunteering may not have identified clear or consistent reasons to explain who volunteers and why because they examined a variety of functional rationales under different volunteering scenarios. Consistent with these findings, in this case study, participants indicated they had many different functional motivations for initially joining the organization, ranging from interest in social justice to simply looking for something to do. Functional motivation in this case does not predict participation and level of involvement. For this reason, we proposed a novel approach based on quality of motivation rather than functionality. Our data points to the relevance of SDT, which suggests that the fulfillment of basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness leads to intrinsic motivation. We specifically examine whether those themes are exhibited at SFUW and whether they can be linked to participation and retention of volunteers.

Autonomy was expressed as a feeling of being able to make one's own choices and pursue activities related to one's interests and values. It appears on all levels of the organization as an important attribute to give and receive. Autonomy generated feelings of trust, enhanced one's responsibility for results, and provided space for innovation, because taking ownership fostered new ideas for SFUW projects. This supports the literature (e.g. Haivas et al., 2012): autonomy supportive environments lead to autonomous motivation. This is not surprising, as the hierarchy in the organization is horizontal, which Courtney (1994) considers beneficial. This implies that successful organizations should employ a more 'flat' organizational structure and facilitate autonomy supportive leadership style, which will ultimately reproduce autonomy as a social norm.

We found that autonomy was connected to competence: being able to choose tasks while being supported by others made the participants more successful in its completion. This process allowed for transfer of skills and expertise as well as for smooth leadership transition.

Competence was implicitly understood as an important part of SFUW experience; the leaders and interns provided support to the volunteers and each other so that they could feel competent and motivated to participate. While negative experiences lowered their feelings of competence and led to frustration, the leaders identified them as learning opportunities and helped others to avoid them in the future. As Gidron (1983) and Deci (1971) would have predicted, acknowledgement by others emerged as an important theme for motivation. It is therefore important that along with making competence an organization norm, to facilitate successful skills transfer and volunteer retention, organizations must acknowledge participants.

Relatedness has not been the focus of SDT researchers perhaps because of their focus on individual behaviors. In this study of a community-based social innovation, it emerged as a prominent feature of all interviews. Consistent with Hodgkinson and Weitzman (1996) and Hobson et al. (1996), we find that the feeling of belonging appears to facilitate both recruitment and retention. Haynes and Trexler (2003) further reported that feeling connected to others became the major motivation over time. This appears to be true for our participants for whom even menial tasks, such as dishwashing, were fun when done with others or for their community. As with autonomy and competence, relatedness was propagated throughout the organization. The participants discussed the need for belonging as essential for the success of their team, to attract more members, but also for connecting to the community at large. The interviews revealed that relatedness also connected with autonomy and competence; belonging fostered trust and

appreciation. We suggest that organizational success can be facilitated by fostering relatedness to one another but also the community.

The interviews revealed that for the participants, the three basic psychological needs were satisfied during their time in SFUW, and this is linked to SFUW member retention, skill transfer, and innovation. The participants described and internalized the concepts that SFUW was an organization where all members experienced autonomy, competence, and relatedness and understood they were essential for success. While they did not articulate the names of these concepts and SDT was unknown to them, the participants implicitly understood the principles and they consciously took steps to provide these experiences to others. This self-propagation of SFUW extended outside the organization; among the members who had graduated, several mentioned that they were looking for and actively trying to recreate the SFUW environment elsewhere. This is the true power of a self-propagating social innovation: to train members to take the principles and apply them wherever they go.

Study limitations

This article describes a case study of SFUW success; while the results offer important insights to explaining success of social innovations, they are not generalizable. In addition, participation was limited to those with strong involvement with the organization. While there is no data on member retention, anecdotal evidence suggests that leaders often start as volunteers moving through internships and no leader or intern has stepped down during their term since the inception of SFUW. This suggests that retention is high once the initial step from a volunteer to an intern position is made. Further study should address whether leaving SFUW or not becoming more involved can be explained by lack of psychological needs satisfaction.

Another potential limitation lies within the critiques of Self-Determination. Miles (2012) summarizes them as not addressing: (i) other potential needs; (ii) conflicts between need satisfaction; (iii) changes in needs over time; and (iv) how need satisfaction attracts people to situations that would satisfy their needs. Our data corroborates SDT in that it does not reveal any additional needs. However, we believe the most-often mentioned additional need, security, would not emerge as relevant given our research site: a relatively safe university environment. Our study further suggests that the needs work in tandem rather than being in conflict; however, it appears that SFUW satisfies all three needs, and therefore our data does not speak to situations in which one or more needs are not satisfied. Third, the participants were SFUW members for a limited amount of time (2–3 years maximum) and were interviewed only once; therefore, it is difficult for changes over time to emerge. Last, our study suggests that it is the functional motivations (one of which is belonging) that initially attract people to SFUW; satisfying the three psychological needs is what is responsible for retention. Hibbert et al. (2003) show that initial ‘unclear’ motivations become articulated over time as volunteers learn about the organization and develop further expectations. This last point deserves further study to examine the link between functional motivations and initial involvement.

Our study did not address participants’ autonomy orientation, which was found to predict volunteer turnover (Gagné, 2003). However, Oostlander et al. (2014) suggest that the strength of personal autonomy orientation is not important in strong autonomy-supportive environments, which SFUW appears to be. Personal autonomy-orientation should be included in future studies.

While some participants receive credit for their SFUW participation, the interviews suggest that receiving credit does not motivate participants. Rather, it enables them to participate

by freeing time that would otherwise be spent on a class; therefore, credit does not appear to function as extrinsic motivation.

Last, we would like to acknowledge that our data is limited to a very specific demographic because neither the SFUW membership nor the UW—Madison student body are diverse. This is fully acknowledged by SFUW leadership who include diversity in their mission, but it also presents a problem as we cannot comment on those who do not have the resources to participate. Using Shye's (2010) classification of three stages of volunteering, we focus on the second stage, motivation to volunteer, rather than the first stage, resources to volunteer, and last stage, opportunities to volunteer. The question of differences in motivations between students of different demographics deserves further study.

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Conclusion

Findings and positioning myself to future problems.

In the first article, we find that the producers of local food in Madison fall into the trap of the local food discourse: they view local food as a personal responsibility and assign an absence of sales to disinterest and the absence of values in some consumers. On the other hand, local residents who do not purchase from them still value good food, they just want the food that is culturally appropriate and affordable. This implies that the policies to improve local food access based on these two outcomes would vastly differ: one would be based on education while the other would address the context of local food retail. In the second article, we describe a community of local food producers who delineate themselves against others, set rules for local food production, and feel the need to help each other and what they describe as their community. This article has implications for new producers entering this community and for overall sustainability of local food. In the third article, we find that community participation could be supported by providing the members with a choice of projects, supporting them to help them feel effective, and most importantly, nurturing a community atmosphere. This article thus provides management advice to not-for-profit organizations about how to motivate volunteers.

The three articles are tied together by the common thread of identifying potentially harmful local food discourse and either identifying or examining potential solutions. However, the articles assume that local food is better than food produced on other scales, thus falling into the “local food trap” (Born & Purcell, 2006). The proposed solutions also do not address the critiques of the community food security and food justice discourses as outlined by Mares and Alkon (2011). In the first two studies I point out how local food producers employ local food discourse to exclude others from the local food community, yet both articles make the normative

assumption that being a part of the “official” local food community is desirable. In addition, the solutions I provide are market oriented, relying on communities of color to be on the receiving end of some aid as in the community food security discourse. Alternately, I emphasize supporting practices to take responsibility for their food production, for instance by gardening, that is criticized in the food justice discourse for putting the work to produce food on already disadvantaged communities. The conclusions of both articles would thus benefit from further research that would address these shortcomings. The third article, while highlighting mechanisms to support participation in an organization that works towards “social justice,” is also uncritical of the organization’s idea of what social justice is and of the organization’s members being mostly White, middle to upper-middle class students. In this way, this study is not dissimilar from the others in that it also to some extent propagates the rhetoric of inequality, personal responsibility, and market solutions to food issues.

The papers also have a research process in common. From the beginning, this process had some elements of positivism: the original proposal identified theories which I thought were relevant, these theories shaped the research questions and methods. Even though I eventually wrote about research questions that differed from the original ones and even though the data itself called for interpretive/theoretical frameworks that might be better applied, these frameworks came from my experiences of working on the specific projects that depended on my coauthor’s worldview and the demands of her funding. Thus, these articles (like much social science) conform to paradigms set out in part by the circumstances. While that is not dissimilar to much of other science, it is important to acknowledge this and work towards better research procedures in the future.

While I appreciate the experience of working on this project and of learning to use new social science tools, it is unlikely that in the future, starting my career as a Visiting Assistant Professor at Emory University, I will continue with such studies. Instead, I will challenge myself to acknowledge neoliberalism as the guiding force of the three major food systems discourses and to also acknowledge the influence of my privilege on the conception and images that emerge from my projects. Second, I challenge myself to move away from positivism towards grounded theory, an inductive approach used by many researchers in the field, and step away from dualism towards a continuum of meanings in my research. Instead of simply applying theory, I want to challenge it, critique it, and improve it.

New questions

Some new, interesting question began to emerge from the conclusions of these studies and from the conversations during my final examination. The first one revolves around the issues of local food behaviors. In this study, I have only examined mostly White producers and sellers of local food and low-income and/or minority residents of Madison about their perceptions of local food behaviors. At the same time, the only Asian farmer and the only White, low-income participant did not appear to follow the pattern of their groups; instead, their rhetoric suggested that they should belong to the group they fit into ethnically. For this reason, it would be interesting to examine whether and how ethnicity/race and class influences the reasons people produce, procure and prepare food that could be considered local.

While the producers' perceptions of the importance of education did not apply to the local residents included in this study, it is possible that it could apply to other consumer groups, for instance more affluent White consumers. Literature would argue that their lack of purchases

is a result of values, but would they explain it similarly? If not, what obstacles would they identify as preventing them from accessing local foods?

The second article identified a production community among a uniform group of local food producers and sellers. While we know that there is a possibility of exclusion from this group, we do not have any evidence about how this process happens and who is not included. If exclusion does happen, this could have negative consequences for producers who are not viewed as belonging to the group. A future study could thus address whether and why some are not considered a part of the group by studying both producers' and consumers' views taken from a more diverse group of producers. An example of this would be the farmers' market in Madison where farmers of different ethnicities sell their products. Given that we saw colorblindness in producers' judgment of their customers, would similar findings appear in attitudes toward producers? In other words, who is a part of this production community, who is not, and for what reason?

The list of questions that need to be answered could continue endlessly and I hope that I can address at least some of them during my career. At the conclusion of this project, I would like to acknowledge all the influences that helped me along the path, be it University of Wisconsin – Madison professors, other scholars, and my community. As I begin a new chapter of my life, I look at this dissertation as a step in the process of continuously re-evaluating both my career and life paths and I hope to one day produce work similarly meaningful to others.

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Table 2. Producers'/Sellers' demographics and business characteristics

Name	Business	Description	On isthmus?	Age/Gender	Race/Ethnicity	Income ¹	Education
Ryan	FA 1	Small farm	Y	32/M	White	1	Some college
Ben	FA 2	Small farm	N	56/M	White	4	Some college
Lis	FA 3	Small farm	Y	64/M	Asian	2	Some high school
Leah	VA 1	Beverage	Y	39/F	White	3	College
Jack	VA 2	Commodity	Y	48/M	White	5	College
Elliot	VA 3	Snack	Y	32/M	White	1	Some college
Jonathan	RE 1	Two restaurants; upscale dining	Y	33/M	White	4	College
Nick	RE 2	Neighborhood bar	Y	32/M	Human	2	College
Nathan	RE 3	Coffee shop; value-added	Y	43/M	White	5	College

Will	RT 1	Retail chain in Madison	Y	43/M	White	4	College
Samantha	RT 2	Retail chain in Wisconsin	N	35/F	White	5	College
Michael	RT 3	Retail chain in the Midwest	Y	39/M	White	5	College

¹Income is based on household income quintiles: 1 = below \$20,260; 2 = \$20,261-\$38,515; 3 = \$38,516-\$62,434; 4 = \$62,435-\$101,577; 5 = above \$101,578

Table 3. Consumer's demographics

Participant	Age/Gender	Race/Ethnicity	Income ¹	Education	Occupation	# people in HH	Location
Grant	71/M	White	1	Graduate	Retired teacher	2	Downtown
Sandra	43/F	White/African American	1	Some college	CNA bartender	2	Far east
Grace	55/F	African American	1	Some post-college	Caregiver for grandchildren	3	South
Sasha	56/F	African American	1	High school	Cook	2	South
Mariah	61/F	African American	1	Some college	Front desk	1	South
Sofia	52/F	Hispanic	2	Graduate	Self-employed (hairdresser)	2	Far east
Antonio	36/M	Hispanic	4	Some post-college	Community center manager Teacher	4	?
Cai	23/M	Asian	4	Some post-college	Student	7	Suburb
Suab	30/F	Asian	1	High school	N/A	4	South
Riya	52/F	Asian	3	College	Finance specialist	4	West

Table 4. Producers' and sellers' interactions based on online search and interview comments

P#	Description	FA1	FA2	FA3	VA1	VA2	VA3	RE1	RE2	RE3	RT1	RT2	RT3	FM	REAP	FairShare
FA 1	Small farm							✓, i	?	?	?	?	?	✓, i		✓
FA 2	Small farm							?	?	?	?	?	?	✓, i		✓
FA 3	Small farm							?	?	?	?	?	?	✓, i		✓
VA 1	Beverage							✓, i	✓	✓	✓, i	✓	✓		✓	✓, i
VA 2	Commodity							✓	✓	?	✓	✓	✓	✓, i	✓	✓
VA 3	Snack										✓, i	✓	✓	✓, i	✓	?
RE 1	Upscale dining	✓	?	?	✓	✓	?							✓	✓	✓
RE 2	Bar	?	?	?	✓	✓	?							X	✓	✓
RE 3	Coffee shop; value-added	?	?	?	?	?	?	(i)						(i)		
RT 1	Retail chain in Madison	?	?	?	✓	✓	✓							✓	✓	✓
RT 2	Retail chain in Wisconsin	?	?	?	✓	✓	✓				i		(i)		✓, i	✓, i
RT 3	Retail chain in the Midwest				✓	✓	✓				(i)					

✓ = a connection online
i = positive mention in interview
(i) = negative mention in an interview
empty space = no apparent connection
? = no connection indicated on websites or interviews

Table 5. Producers'/Sellers' business characteristics

Business	Description	Sources from	Distributes to	Size
FA 1	Small farm	WI	WI	Small farm
FA 2	Small farm	WI	WI	Small farm
FA 3	Small farm	WI	WI	Small farm in a cooperative
VA 1	Beverage	US; abroad	WI	Micro-manufacturer (<16,000 barrels)
VA 2	Commodity	WI; US; abroad	US, Canada	?
VA 3	Snack	US; abroad	WI	?
RE 1	Upscale dining	WI; US; abroad	WI	Two venues
RE 2	Bar	WI; US	WI	One venue
RE 3	Coffee shop; value-added	Abroad (coffee)	WI	Seven venues
RT 1	2 locations in the city	WI; US; abroad	Madison	Two stores
RT 2	3 locations in WI	WI; US; abroad	WI	Three stores
RT 3	Multiple locations in the Midwest	WI; US; abroad	Midwest	240 stores

Table 6. Study participants, their student/advisor status, and their roles in SFUW organization

Slow Food role	Name	Generation
Intern	Monica	In between
	Cecilia	Current
	Sophie	In-between
	Sarah	In-between
	Margo	Current
	Chloe	Current
	Lucy	Current
	Phoebe	Original
Leadership	Marleen	Original
	Peter	In-between
	Greta	In-between
	Marilyn	In-between
	Tina	Current
	Alexis	In-between
	Patrick	Original
	Edward	Original
Advisor Collaborator	Jackie	Original
	Liza	Current
	Tyler	Current

Appendix

Interview Questions Article 1 + 2

The following is an interview guide. Not all questions were explicitly asked of or answered by all participants. Some participants may have answered a question as a part of a different question; some may have declined to answer a question. Similarly, this list does not include individual follow-up or clarifying questions.

Producers/Sellers:

1. How would you describe your _____ (insert type of business)?
2. How would you define local food? What do you not consider to be local food?
3. Why is local food important?
4. What do you produce/sell? How do you decide what to produce/sell?
5. Where do you source your ingredients? How?
6. Where do you distribute your food to?
7. Who is your community? How would you characterize them?
8. Who purchases your products? Who does not? Why?
9. Can you describe your most and least rewarding experience?

Consumers:

1. Please, describe your favorite meal.
2. Where do you purchase/procure food and why?
3. How do you decide what to buy?
4. Can you tell me about your experiences with cooking?

5. Can you tell me about your experiences with gardening?
6. Can you tell me about your experiences with the farmers' market?
7. How would you define local food? What do you not consider to be local food?
8. Is local food important?